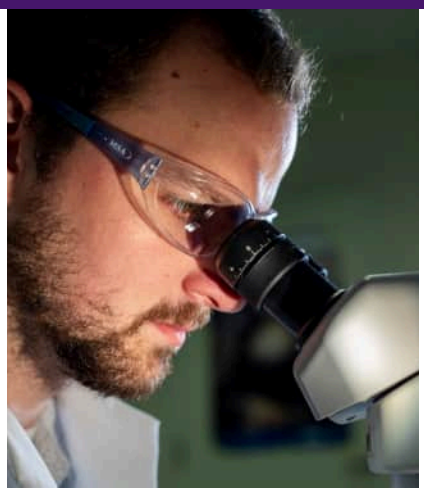
University at Albany
STATE UNIVERSITY OF NEW YORK

Department of Biological Sciences

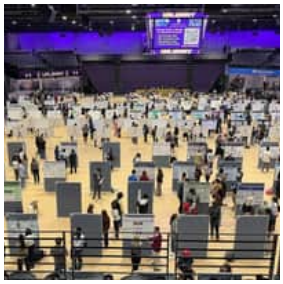
2025-2026 Academic Year

August 2026 Vol. 6









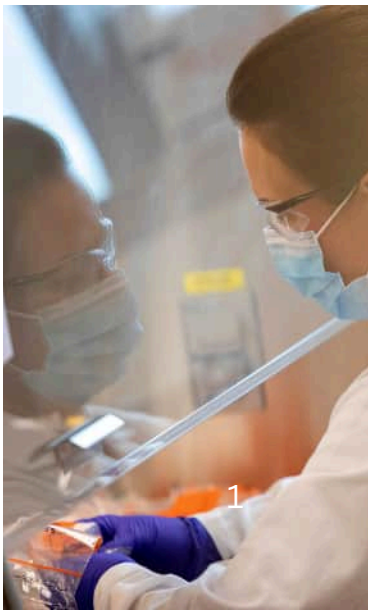














Inside this Issue:

- Faculty and Staff News and Achievements
- Spotlights on our Students
- Research Highlights
- Events and Seminars
- Curriculum and Academic Updates
- Community Outreach and Engagement

University at Albany
STATE UNIVERSITY OF NEW YORK
College of Arts & Sciences

TABLE OF CONTENTS

03 Message from the Chair

04 New Biology Department Faculty

The University at Albany Department of Biological Sciences is excited to welcome Dr. Kristyn Lizbinski as a new faculty member. Dr. Lizbinski joins the Department of Biological Sciences with an impressive background in neuroscience research, teaching, student mentorship and service thus bringing expertise that will strengthen UAlbany's Interdisciplinary Neuroscience Program.

05 Student Spotlights

The undergraduate and graduate students of the Biology Department represent the very best of the student body at the University of Albany, and here are just a few of their stories.

07 Student Honors

The achievements of UAlbany Biology Department undergraduate and graduate students are recognized both inside and outside the Department and University.

17 Events and Seminars

The UAlbany Biology Department hosts an ongoing series of events and seminars bringing together our students and faculty with world-renowned experts in their fields, including many Nobel Prize winners. Here are some from this year.

22 Faculty Achievements, Publications, and Awards

A review of publications, appearances, research grants, and awards given to the exceptional faculty of the UAlbany Biology Department; also includes information on some notable recent graduates from our faculty labs.

30 Faculty/Researcher Spotlights

38 Faculty Honors

46 Faculty Retirements

Dr. Richard "Rick" Cunningham is retiring from the University at Albany's Department of Biological Sciences. Chair of the Department of Biological Sciences from 2014 to 2024, Rick leaves behind a remarkable legacy as a scientist, educator, mentor, and colleague.

47 Alumni Stories

UAlbany Biology Department Alumni have been successful in a wide variety of fields, including medicine, academia, industry ... even aviation! Here are some of their stories.

51 Community Outreach and Engagement

53 Faculty Obituaries

55 Coming Events







Message from the Chair

As we begin the new academic year, I feel grateful and proud of the amazing accomplishments of our faculty, staff, and students. This past year has been one of growth, collaboration and innovation across the Department of Biological Sciences.

Our department continues to shine in research, teaching, and community outreach. From groundbreaking discoveries to impactful community engagement and student mentorship, the work being done here is truly inspiring. This past year, many of our students participated in Showcase Day and our Undergraduate Research Symposium, and many students won prestigious awards!

Looking ahead, we are excited to be moving forward with two new undergraduate degree programs: a Bachelor of Science in Forensic Science and a Bachelor of Science in Neuroscience, developed in partnership with the Department of Psychology. Both programs are on track for launch in August 2027 and will provide students with cutting-edge training for careers in research, healthcare, and public service.

This year, we welcome Dr. Kristyn Lizbinski to our ranks and celebrate the successes of our former Department Chair, Richard Cunningham, who retires August 31. We remain committed to fostering a vibrant, inclusive, and forward-thinking academic environment. We are excited to expand our partnerships and enhance our programs as we continue preparing the next generation of scientists, healthcare professionals, educators, and leaders.

Warm regards,
Melinda Larsen
Willams Raycheff Distinguished Professor and Chair
Department of Biological Sciences
Affiliated faculty, The RNA Institute
University at Albany, SUNY

UALBANY

Department of Biological Sciences

NEW BIOLOGY DEPARTMENT FACULTY

Welcoming Dr. Kristyn Lizbinski
to the Department of Biological Sciences



The University at Albany is excited to welcome Dr. **Kristyn Lizbinski** as a new faculty member. Dr. Lizbinski joins the Department of Biological Sciences with an impressive background in neuroscience research, teaching, student mentorship and service thus bringing expertise that will strengthen UAlbany's Interdisciplinary Neuroscience Program.

Dr. Lizbinski earned a double major in Neuroscience and Philosophy from The University of Scranton. She then received her Ph.D. in Biology from West Virginia University where she studied how chemical signals in the brain influence the way odors are detected and processed. Following her doctorate at WVU, Dr. Lizbinski joined Yale University's Department of Neuroscience and Wu Tsai Institute in 2019 as a Postdoctoral Research Fellow.

Her path to becoming a neuroscientist began as an undergraduate with broad interests in both science and the humanities. Initially considering a career in medicine, she discovered a passion for research through her neuroscience coursework and hands-on laboratory experiences. Reflecting on her undergraduate studies at UScranton, Dr. Lizbinski credits the many opportunities to conduct independent research and the ability to work closely with faculty as key experiences that convinced her to pursue a scientific and research career.

Dr. Lizbinski's research investigates how the brain helps organisms make sense of the world around them by detecting, analyzing and interpreting odors. By employing imaging and computational technologies, she seeks to better understand the connections between brain activity, learning, and behavior. To date, her work has been published in leading scientific journals that include Current Biology, eNeuro, and Frontiers in Cellular Neuroscience. Dr. Lizbinski's contributions to neuroscience research have earned her the Ruth L. Kirschstein National Research Service Award (NRSA) Postdoctoral Fellowship from the National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders (NIDCD).

Dr. Lizbinski is also dedicated to teaching and mentoring the next generation of scientists. Throughout her career, she has taught courses in neuroscience, cell biology, and physiology, and has mentored undergraduate and graduate students pursuing careers in medicine, research, education, and other scientific fields. She is committed to helping students discover and achieve their goals. Drawing on her own academic experiences, Dr. Lizbinski points out the importance of curiosity, persistence, and mentorship in helping students succeed.

Dr. Lizbinski has also been active in community service through participating in neuroscience seminar committees and career development programs as well as reviewing manuscripts for leading scientific journals.

The Department of Biological Sciences is thrilled that Dr. Lizbinski has joined the UAlbany community. Hired through an institutional grant from the **Simon's Foundation**, her innovative research program, passion for teaching, commitment to mentorship, and dedication to service will provide outstanding opportunities for students and colleagues while contributing to the mission and goals of the University, College, and Department.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT SPOTLIGHT

MANUELA MONTOYA-GIRALDO



Manuela Montoya-Giraldo

UAlbany Student Manuela Montoya-Giraldo: Bridging Research and Enterpreneurship

The University at Albany's Department of Biological Sciences is extremely proud to feature **Manuela Montoya-Giraldo**, a fourth-year Ph.D. candidate in UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences Molecular, Cellular, Developmental and Neural (MCDN) program. She currently does research in the laboratory of Associate Professor Cheryl Andam and is also a member in UAlbany's Spring 2026 RISE program.

Manuela was born and raised in Colombia, South America where she earned a BSc in Microbiology. Manuela worked as a researcher in marine microbiology for four years at the Marine Research Institute (INVEMAR) prior to joining UAlbany's MCDN program. As a member of INVEMAR, Manuela studied how microorganisms from sea sediments in the Caribbean can be used to discover novel natural compounds. Manuela's interest in combining molecular biology, microbiology, and bioinformatics led her to pursue a PhD at UAlbany where she continues to strengthen her academic and research skills while studying microbial populations, genomics, and phylogenetics in host–microbe communities. Since beginning her doctoral studies in 2022, Manuela has publications in journals such as Nature Communications, Communications Medicine, and Microbial Genomics, and a 2026 manuscript under review on Staphylococcus aureus.



She has also received several honors that include the American Society for Microbiology Future Leaders Mentorship Fellowship (2025–2027), UAlbany's Academic Leadership Award, and multiple awards for her research presentations.

In addition to her doctoral research, Manuela was selected this Spring to participate in the Research and Innovators Startup Exchange (RISE) program through the UAlbany Innovation Center located in ETEC. The RISE program brings researchers and students together to find ways to turn scientific discoveries into real-life applications.

From an interview with Manuela discussing her research and participation in UAlbany's RISE program.

- *Summarize the research that you are currently conducting.*

  Actinobacteria are a major source of antimicrobial and drug precursors, and one of the most studied genera in this group is Streptomyces. These bacteria have been the source of many clinically relevant antibiotics used in medicine, agriculture, and biotechnology. My research in the Andam Lab focuses on understanding Streptomyces diversity and biosynthetic potential when isolated from the skin and fur of insectivorous bats. I aim to uncover the genetic mechanisms that drive this diversity and to gain a better understanding of how interactions with bats in cave environments influence the discovery of new antimicrobial compounds.

- *Looking back, what motivated you to choose the Andam lab for your studies?*

  I began working on Actinobacteria from deep-sea sediments at INVEMAR in Colombia before joining the **Andam lab**. I developed a strong interest in Streptomyces species during that time. I found it exciting that the Andam Lab was studying Streptomyces from bats which offered me a unique and very interesting research opportunity. I first connected with the lab as a summer fellow in the 2021 Bioinformatics Fellowship offered by UAlbany's RNA Institute. I applied to the graduate program following that experience and joined the lab where I now conduct my thesis research under Professor Andam's guidance.

- *What motivated you to choose this specific topic for your research?*

  I have been interested in how organisms interact within ecosystems. I became very interested in studying microbes in relation to the organisms they live with. My curiosity about Streptomyces ultimately led me to this type of research and to join the Andam lab.

- *What advice would you give to students interested in pursuing research?*

  I would emphasize the importance of curiosity. I believe that taking time to ask questions and explore ideas can lead to meaningful discoveries. My advice to students seeking to enroll in research is to always find time to be curious.

- *What are your next steps?*

  I am interested in moving back to marine microbiology. I plan to focus on coral holobionts and integrate my training in molecular biology, bioinformatics, and microbiology. I hope to contribute to coral restoration and conservation efforts through this interdisciplinary approach.

- *What is the RISE program, and what drew you to apply?*

  I participated in the RISE program offered by the UAlbany Innovation Center which bridges research and entrepreneurship. I was drawn to the program because it provides hands-on experience in developing ideas into business concepts. I was particularly interested in exploring career paths beyond traditional academic and industry roles.

Manuela's participation in the RISE program reflects UAlbany's and the Department of Biological Sciences commitment as a Carnegie R1 institution in supporting research excellence, interdisciplinary training, innovation and entrepreneurship.

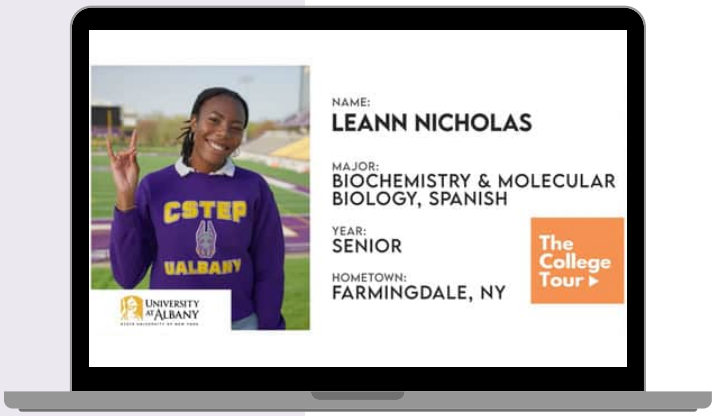
You can read Manuela's full interview at: https://www.albany.edu/news-center/news/2026-biology-research-meets-entrepreneurship-through-rise

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UNDERGRADUATE STUDENT SPOTLIGHT

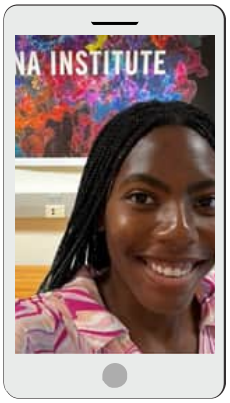
LEANN NICHOLAS

UAlbany Biology Undergraduate Featured in Streaming Series "The College Tour"



The Department of Biological Sciences is proud of **Leann Nicholas**, a double major in Biochemistry & Molecular Biology and Spanish who is featured in the episode of The College Tour: https://www.albany.edu/the-college-tour#watch. The College Tour is a nationally streaming series on Amazon Prime Video that showcases the personal stories and experiences of college students across the United States. The show's main goal is to give prospective students and families an inside look at college life that includes academic, research and internship opportunities, athletics, student organizations, etc.

Each episode features students from a college or university who share their journeys and achievements while showcasing how they were able to navigate college, pursue their goals, and take advantage of the resources available to them at their academic institution.



The Department of Biological Sciences is proud of Leann Nicholas, a double major in Biochemistry & Molecular Biology and Spanish who is featured in the episode of The College Tour: https://www.albany.edu/the-college-tour#watch. The College Tour is a nationally streaming series on Amazon Prime Video that showcases the personal stories and experiences of college students across the United States. The show's main goal is to give prospective students and families an inside look at college life that includes academic, research and internship opportunities, athletics, student organizations, etc. Each episode features students from a college or university who share their journeys and achievements while showcasing how they were able to navigate college, pursue their goals, and take advantage of the resources available to them at their academic institution.

Leann, who is part of the Upstate Accelerated Scholars BS/MD Program, recently began her first year of medical school at SUNY Upstate Medical University's Norton College of Medicine while completing her undergraduate degree at UAlbany. The Upstate Accelerated Scholars BS/MD Program provides a pathway for highly qualified students interested in medicine.

If accepted, students are guaranteed admission to SUNY Upstate Medical University's Norton College of Medicine upon entering an approved undergraduate program. The Norton College of Medicine is known for its small class sizes, interdisciplinary clinical training, and commitment to serving diverse and underserved areas across New York State. Leann's acceptance into this competitive program enabled her to directly pursue her medical studies after completing her three years of undergraduate coursework at UAlbany.



A native of Farmingdale, N.Y., Leann has excelled both academically and athletically during her time at UAlbany. A captain of the track and field team, she holds the University's indoor and outdoor triple jump records and has earned numerous athletic distinctions. As a member of the Albany community, Leann was named an America East Presidential Scholar, an honor awarded only to student-athletes who earn a cumulative GPA of 3.75 or higher while completing their undergraduate coursework.

While athletics has been a major part of her life, Leann's main objective has always been to become a doctor and practice medicine. Born in Queens to parents who immigrated from Jamaica and St. Vincent and the Grenadines, she began volunteering in high school and found that the experience confirmed her commitment to a career in healthcare.

At UAlbany, she validated her commitment to medicine by serving as vice president of the Doctors for Hope Executive Board, tutoring peers, and volunteering with the Red Cross and Chasing Health. Leann also conducted an independent research project examining Spanish-language attitudes in New York State medical settings which earned her the Undergraduate Honors Thesis Award at UAlbany's Spring 2025 Showcase Day. Furthermore, she conducted DNA nanotechnology research in the Chandrasekaran Lab at UAlbany's RNA Institute.

Leann's impressive undergraduate accomplishments made her a perfect student representative for The College Tour. During the premiere event held last fall, she and her fellow students showcased UAlbany's academics, research opportunities, student organizations, and overall campus experience. As Leann continues her journey through medical school while completing her final requirements for her undergraduate degrees, she stands out as an example of the drive, curiosity, and leadership that defines UAlbany students, faculty, and staff. The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Leann on all that she has achieved at UAlbany and looks forward to seeing her realize her dream of becoming a medical doctor.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UNDERGRADUATE STUDENT SPOTLIGHT:

ASAMOAH-NANI



Asamoah-Nani

Asamoah-Nani grew up in Ghana where learning, discipline, and community were central parts of his daily life. Raised in an environment that placed a strong emphasis on education, he developed strong study habits and a lasting appreciation for learning from an early age.

Supported by his family and teachers, this early appreciation for education helped prepare him for the move to higher education in the United States.

After moving to the Bronx, he found comfort in a strong sense of community that helped him adjust to a new country and continue working toward his academic goals.

When selecting a university, the University at Albany stood out for its academic strengths and the many opportunities available beyond the classroom. As a biological sciences major, Asamoah-Nani was particularly drawn to hands-on research experiences that connect classroom learning with real-world applications and support his goal of pursuing a career in healthcare.

In addition to his studies, he has been actively involved in campus life in a variety of roles. He serves as a resident assistant, participates on the Men's Club Soccer Team, and is a purple and gold ambassador and UAlbany Fund Representative.

He is also involved with Five Quad Volunteer Ambulance Service, the MCAT Club, and works as a Research Assistant and intern with UAlbany Athletics.

Through these experiences, he continues to build leadership skills, gain research experience, and contribute to the UAlbany community.

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENTS MASRI AND RAMASAMY HONORED WITH SUNY CHANCELLOR AWARD



Massa Masri



Raji Ramasamy

The Department of Biological Sciences is proud to congratulate **Massa Masri** and **Senbahavalli "Raji" Ramasamy** on receiving the *2025 SUNY Chancellor's Award for Student Excellence*. The annual SUNY Chancellor's Award is the highest honor awarded to SUNY students and recognizes outstanding achievements in academics, leadership, campus involvement and community service.

Although their paths to UAlbany were very different, both students have distinguished themselves through academic excellence, service and a commitment to improving the lives of others through a future career in healthcare.

Originally from Syria, Massa came to the United States as a teenager before enrolling at UAlbany. As a biology major with a minor in business, she combined her interest in science with a passion for healthcare. During her undergraduate studies, she participated in research, took on leadership roles in student organizations and became the first member of her family to pursue a career in medicine. Following graduation, Massa plans to attend medical school with the long-term goal of opening a medical practice that serves her community.

Raji, a member of the Guilderland community, chose UAlbany for the opportunities it offered both inside and outside the classroom. A biology major with minors in leadership and chemistry, Raji excelled academically while volunteering through the UAlbany's Honors College and the Five Quad Ambulance Service. After graduating with honors, she plans to spend a year working in a clinic before applying to medical school.

The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Massa and Raji on this well-deserved recognition. Their accomplishments confirm the academic excellence, leadership, and commitment to service that define UAlbany students and we look forward to the positive impact they will have as future healthcare professionals.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENTS ADELEKUN, ALIYEVA, EHRBAR, AND TAVAREZ HONORED

UNIVERSITY AT ALBANY



Joey Tavarez



Ibrahim Adelakun



Dylan Ehrbar



Asmer Aliyeva

UAlbany Biology Students are Graduate Pathway for Scholars (GPS) Awardees

The University at Albany, College of Arts and Sciences, and the Department of Biological Sciences congratulate the awardees of the 2025 & 2026 Graduate Pathway for Scholars (GPS). The GPS program supports Ph.D. students in the Departments of Biological Sciences and Chemistry who aspire to academic careers. Attendees gathered for an hour-long celebration emphasizing the accomplishments and research of the awardees.

Distinguished Biology Professor and senior advisor of the RNA Institute **Marlene Belfort** opened the program. As the founder of this program, she opened with an overview of the GPS program and its mission. She was followed by Dean Altarriba. Dean Altarriba acknowledged the awardees on their accomplishments while emphasizing the University at Albany's and the College of Arts and Sciences commitment to supporting GPS program. She also noted that the program recognizes exceptional Ph.D. students in Biological Sciences and Chemistry who seek academic careers and expands opportunities for them to seek additional training and to stay connected with UAlbany to facilitate their pursuit for an academic position. Acknowledging the analogy of GPS with a compass, Dean Altarriba encouraged the GPS fellows and all the students in attendance to "set their sights on their personal goals, stay the course, and remain focused no matter the distractions along the way".

Following the announcements of the Fellows and Honorable Mention recipients by Professor **Melinda Larsen**, Chair of the Department of Biological Sciences and Associate Professor of Biology **Cara Pager**, Chair of the Biology CARES committee, the program featured research presentations from both current and past GPS Fellows and Honorable Mention awardees:

Graduate Pathway for Scholars (GPS) Fellows:

- **Joey Tavarez** (Biological Sciences), 2026 GPS Fellow
  "Mapping How Fibroblasts Respond to Tissue Injury and Orchestrate Tissue Remodeling"
- **Ibrahim Adelakun** (Chemistry), 2026 GPS Fellow
  "Towards Regulating Biological Activities with Azobenzene Modified Nucleotides"

Honorable Mention Recipients:

- **Dylan Ehrbar** (Biological Sciences), 2026 Honorable Mention
  "Significant Shifts in Codon Usage Bias Associated with Age and Age-Related Diseases"
- **Asmer Aliyeva** (Biological Sciences), 2026 Honorable Mention
  "Dysregulation of Alternative Splicing in CAG Repeat Expansion Spinocerebellar Ataxias"

Featured Past GPS Awardees:

- **Michelle Urman** (Biological Sciences), 2025 GPS Fellow
  "Worms and Women in STEM: A Journey of Research and Discovery"
- **Andrew Muñoz Gamba** (Biological Sciences), 2025 Honorable Mention
  "Zika Virus Adaptation in Mosquito and Mammalian Hosts"

The GPS program was established in 2024 by three College of Arts & Sciences faculty members affiliated with the RNA Institute: Distinguished Professor Marlene Belfort, Associate Professor Cara Pager, and Professor Emerita Rabi Ann Musah. The program's main goal is to help fill open faculty positions with talented and exceptional candidates while providing mentorship and support. The GPS program is currently administered by Professors Belfort and Pager with Fellows selected by committee members from the Departments of Chemistry, Atmospheric and Environmental Sciences, and Biology.

Congratulations to all recipients of the Graduate Pathway for Scholars (GPS) Fellowship!

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENTS SHINE AT ANNUAL UALBANY SHOWCASE DAY APRIL 30, 2026



The UAlbany Showcase highlights and celebrates student excellence through displays and exhibitions of undergraduate and graduate research, scholarslhip, creative endeavors, and applied/experiential learning. The Department of Biological Sciences students' presentations represented a major component of the 2026 event.

Winners

Best Undergraduate Research: Afifa Ahmed, Margaret Amarjargal, Mia Call, Camryn Clark, Sylvia Drenkalo, Dylan Ehrbar, Sophia Giler

M.S. Research: Layla Farmer

Ph.D. Research: Noah LeFever

Showcase Advisor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Jeanette Altarriba	Camryn Clark	Attentional Biases in Anxiety: A Comparative Review of Cognitive and Neurobiological Theories
Thomas Begley	Dylan Ehrbar	Functional Gene Clusters Revealed by Codon Usage Patterns in the Human Genome
	Humphrey Omeoga	The tRNA Writer MnmA Translationally Regulates Key Transcription Factors Critical to Environmental and Physiological Changes
	Cady Roselli	Investigating the Role of tRNA Sulfurtransferase-Mediated Modification in Regulating Growth and Cellular Properties in E. coli
Andrew Berglund	Sai Sravani Nimishakavi	Role of domains in Muscleblind-like 1 RNA-Binding Protein in Alternative Splicing Regulation
	Sharon Shaughnessy	Innate Immune Activation in Myotonic Dystrophy Type 1
	Carter Wilkins	Bioinformatic Identification and Analysis of Common Splicing Errors in Myotonic Dystrophy Type 1 (DM1) and Fuchs' Endothelial Corneal Dystrophy (FECD)
Pauline Carrico	Khadija Williams	A Comparative Look at Healthcare Access and Equity in Portugal
Alan Chen	Lindsey Farmer	Improved Measurement Strategies for Obstetric Blood Loss
Douglas Conklin	Sidney Charlemagne	A Phylogenetic Analysis of BTK- C Across Various Species
	Jessica Teague	Alternative ABL1 Isoforms Generated by Distinct Transcription Start Sites in Leukemia
Soma Dash	Aminata Fofana	Inside the Regulatory Switchboard: Med23 & the Control of Developmental Gene Programs
	Kate Hayes	Global Transcriptional Regulation of Tissue-Specific Development
	Diya Mangatt	Med24 Is Required for Normal Feeding Behavior in Zebrafish
	Yomilka Valerio	Mutations in Mediator Complex Results in Cranial Skeletal Abnormalities
Bijan Dey	Aiden Cho	Transcriptomic Analysis of Gene Expression Changes in Duchenne Muscular Dystrophy
	Ridita Das	Comparative Analysis of Different Muscle Samples in Duchenne muscular dystrophy (DMD) using RNA seq Analysis
	Adriana Pichardo	Young niche in mice influences the gene expression of aged Muscle Stem Cells
	Senbahavalli Ramasamy	Single-Cell Transcriptomic Comparison Reveals Gut Microbiota Modulation of Muscle Pathology in Duchenne Muscular Dystrophy

Winners, Best Undergraduate Research: ***Camryn Clark, Dylan Ehrbar***

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENTS SHINE AT ANNUAL UALBANY SHOWCASE DAY (CONT'D)
APRIL 30, 2026

Showcase Advisor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Dylan Farnsworth	Serafina Parvattan	Zebrafish Model Systems for Myotonic Dystrophy
Paolo Forni	Margaret Amarjargal	Gli3 Mutant Mice as a Model to Observe the Effects of Aberrant Olfactory Ensheathing Cell Development and Terminal Nerve Migration
	Mia Call	Prokr2CreERT2 Mouse Line Unravels the Mysteries of the Terminal Nerve
	Shraddha Divekar	Trp73 involvement in the rodent olfactory system development
	Layla Farmer	Utilizing Necdin-Null Mice as a Model to Study GnRH-1 Neuron Migration and Terminal Nerve Development
	Noah LeFever	Trp73: A Critical Transcription Factor for Maturation and Survival of Neurons of the Olfactory Systems
	Catherine Lienemann	Prokr2, a Key Marker of the terminal nerve is expressed by a subset of GnRH-1 Neurons
Gabriele Fuchs	Evan Corwin	Generation of a dual luciferase reporter construct to investigate the relationship between translation initiation and frameshifting efficiency
	Elizabeth Hacker	Analyzing Ribosomal Frameshifting via a Reporter Assay
	Grace Heiner	Ribosome Frameshifting on the PLEKHM2 Signal
	Shecid Millan	Measuring the Impact of Ribosome Spacing on HIV-1 Frameshifting Efficiency
Michael Gerdes	Matthew Conover	Chemical profiling of Coral Mucosa Extracts and their Potential Antibiotic Properties
Ken Halvorsen	Mariam Sow	Fluorescently Labeled Oligonucleotides into DNA Nanoswitches for Improved Detection
Melinda Larsen	Julissa Forde	Using antagomirs to knockdown TGFβ1-induced miRNAs driving fibrosis during Myofibroblast Transition
	Erin Gillan	Age Related Alterations in Aging Salivary Glands
	Taiwo (Annabelle) Ogunyale	Schwann Cells as Potential Drivers of Fibrotic Remodeling in the Salivary Gland
	Rafael Pena	Remediating salivary gland fibrosis following injury through scaffold-mediated delivery of stromal cells
	Pearl De-Veer	Radiation-Induced Senescence Remodels Salivary Gland Epithelial Cell States and Is Modulated by Fisetin Treatment
ChangHwan Lee	Sofia Adele Castro	Investigating the role of kinesin microtubule motor genes in stem cell niche nuclear positioning during aging
	Reagan Conrad	Investigating the role Glutamine-rich domains in Notch Signaling Regulation and Stem Cell Control
	Marissa Kearns	Investigating the effects of stem cell niche on germline stem cell function and fecundity in C. elegans
	Avairee McConnell	Effects of Metabolic Signals on Notch-Dependent Transcription, Germline Stem Cell Activities, and Fertility
Michelle Lennartz	Elianna T. Cruz Gonzalez	Commonalities and differences between ATF4 and ATF3 upon induction of different branches of the integrated stress response (ISR)
	Ishaan Singh	Role of PKCε in Endocytosis of Lipid by Macrophages
	Parmesh Thakoordial	Dissecting transactivation by the ΔN-specific N-terminal domains of p63 and p73
J. Andres Melendez	Esam Abisse	Investigating Oxidative Control of SASP Markers to Identify DNA Nanostructures Inflammatory Potential
	Jazlynn Sotelo	Redox Regulation of SASP Gene Expression During Hydrogen Peroxide–Induced Senescence
Cara Pager	Nurat Affinnih	Investigation of Ilhéus virus infection in mosquito and mammalian cell lines
	Mya Drake	West Nile Virus

Winners, Best Undergraduate Research: ***Margaret Amarjargal, Mia Call***

Winner, M.S. Research: ***Layla Farmer***

Winner, Ph.D. Research: ***Noah LeFever***

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENTS SHINE AT ANNUAL UALBANY SHOWCASE DAY (CONT'D)
APRIL 30, 2026

Showcase Advisor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Cara Pager	Giovanna Vianna Esko	Infectious Mononucleosis
	Jacklynne Osorio-Hernandez	Hepatitis C Virus: Understanding Risk, Transmission, and Prevention in College Communities
	Ellen Heyns	Rabies
	Kaliyah Hull	Viruses Affecting Campus: Noro Virus
	Mehreen Khan	Hepatitis B
	Navid Khosrojerdi	Measles risk to college students: What exactly is the Measles Virus and how can you avoid it?
	Molly McGrath	An Overview of Human Papillomavirus, its Impact on College Students, and Prevention Methods
	Courtney Munderville	Protecting Public Health: Communicable Disease Surveillance in New York State
	Chamyuktha Senthilkumar	Human Immunodeficiency Virus:
John Polk	Heeqmat Bakrin	Assessing gait stability during gait tasks using wearable sensors.
Kaalak Reddy	Aatia Mreedu	Screening Candidate Modifiers of Toxic RNA in Myotonic Dystrophy Type 1
Annalisa Scimemi	Izabella Czajkowski	Neuronal glutamate transporters encode dopamine co-release with glutamate and GABA
	Baran Mohammadi	Neuronal glutamate transporters limit dopamine release in the striatum
	Peter Oloruntola	Hippocampal Layer-Specific Changes in Protein Expression in Circadian Rhythms
	Noah Satterlee	The Neuronal Glutamate Transporter EAAC1 Limits Dopamine Release In The Striatum
Hannah Shorrock	Afifa Ahmed	Cross-Disease Small Molecule Screening Identifies Therapeutic Candidates for CAG Repeat Expansion Disorders
	Ryan O'Connell	Synthesizing Analogs of CAGbr01 for Improved Reduction of CAG Repeat Expression
	Adrianna Vidot	Alternative Splicing and Differential Gene Expression Reveal Potential Blood Biomarkers in SCA2 and SCA3
Stephanie Da Silva Rodrigues De Souza	Sania Bhanger	Genome-based exploration of Secondary Metabolite Potential in Acidomicrobial Bacteria from Amazonian forest and adjacent cattle pasture soil
	Inca Borges	Microbial Ecosystems: Visualizing Biodiversity Loss with Chromogenic Agar
	Maeve Donnelly	Uncovering Virulence in the Human Microbiome: A Focus on Virulence Factors in Commensal Bacteria
	Emma Doughty	Genomic Surveillance of Guillain-Barré Syndrome-Associated Genes in Campylobacter Isolates from Non-Human Sources
	Mya Drake	Genome Mining of different bacterial group isolated from platinum mine tailings in South Africa.
	Sylvia Drenkalo	Exploring Biosynthetic Gene Clusters in Bacteroidota and Actinobacteria from Platinum Mine Tailings Soils in South Africa through Genome Mining
	Matthew Duell	Exploring Biosynthetic Gene Clusters in different bacterial genomes from South African mine tilling's soils through Genome Mining
	Sophia Giler	Global Analysis and Comparative Genomics of Klebsiella pneumoniae ST258

Winners, Best Undergraduate Research: ***Afifa Ahmed, Sylvia Drenkato, Sophia Giler***

Winner, Best Class Project: ***Jacklynne Osorio-Hernandez***

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENTS SHINE AT ANNUAL UALBANY SHOWCASE DAY (CONT'D)
APRIL 30, 2026

Showcase Advisor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Stephanie Da Silva Rodrigues De Souza	Jacklynne Osorio-Hernandez	Exploring Bacterial Biosynthetic Gene Clusters from Brazil for Novel Antimicrobial Discovery
	Wayde Huang	An analysis of Amazonian soil microbes' antibacterial properties through BGC analysis
	Rahid Khan	Biosynthetic Gene Cluster Diversity in Burkholderiales from a Fire-Adapted Ecosystem
	Vivek Lanka	Using genome-mining approach to detect biosynthetic gene clusters (BGCs) in high-quality metagenome-assembled genomes (MAGs) isolated from soil samples from the Albany Pine Bush Preserve (APBP)
	Alexis Mastrantuono	Yin-Yang of Micro-Organisms
	Baran Mohammadi	Biosynthetic Gene Cluster Diversity in Heavy Metal–Impacted South African Soils
	Wendy Oppong	Exploring Biosynthetic Gene Clusters in Pseudomonadales group from metal-stressed soil environments in South Africa through Genome Mining
	Ethan Palacio	Dissemination and Diversity of Antimicrobial Resistance Genes in the Human Microbiome
	Andre Piper	Visualizing Antibiotic Resistance: "The Silent Pandemic" Through Agar Art
	Ibraheem Ropri	Exploring Biosynthetic Gene Clusters in the Actinomycetota bacterial phylum from Amazonian rainforest soils through Genome Mining
	Tristan Suarez	Evaluation of Commercial Disinfectant Wipes for Removal of Escherichia coli K-12 from a Non-Porous Acrylic Surface
Shannon Stephens	Tristan Suarez	Atlas Alignment of Mouse Brain Sections Using FIJI and the BigWarp Plugin
Ryan Thurman	Kiran Smitka	GC/MS Analysis of Volatile Organic Compounds from Sus scofia domesticus Bones
Max Turner	Rishita Nagothi	The effect of motivational state on visual processing
	Gabriela Valdivieso	Visual Processing in Drosophila melanogaster
Elise Vogt	Grace Bullard	Mad Cow in Humans! (variant Creutzfeldt-Jakob Disease)
	Emma Doughty	Cervical Cancer
	Unisha Gurung	Eczema
	Patrick Johnson	Psoriasis
	Nevin Joseph	Hyperthyroidism (Graves Disease)
	Minsang Kim	Fibrodysplasia ossificans progressiva(FOP)
	Esther Kyambadde	Alzheimer's Disease
	Sachin Lachman	Bells Palsy
	Taniyah Larkins	Parkinson's Disease
	Catherine Lienemann	Guillain-Barré Syndrome
	Yutaro Matsuzawa	Carcinomatous Meningitis
	Raina Waraich	Duchenne Muscular Dystrophy
Ting Wang	Sanjida Ahmed	Small Molecule Modified Polycyclic Compound (MPC03) Synthesis and Screening in Myotonic Dystrophy Type 1
Yubing Xie	Winnie Ou	Evaluation of Extracellular Matrix (ECM) Changes in Steroid-Induced 3D Glaucoma Models
Damian Zuloaga	Maycen Schaefer	Effects of androgens and chronic stress on anxiety-related behavior and stress-induced neural activity

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

43RD ANNUAL UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCH SYMPOSIUM
MAY 1, 2026



At UAlbany undergraduate science students participate in research for credit and play a key role in designing experiments, testing hypotheses, conducting experiments, analyzing data, interpreting results and finally presenting their conclusions. This year's symposium featured twenty oral presentations from various UAlbany departments, including Biological Sciences, Chemistry, Psychology and Biomedical Sciences, as well as institutions such as the RNA Institute, New York State Department of Health, and Albany Medical College.

Microbiology and Infectious Disease Presentations

Mentor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Cheryl Andam	Sam Azadi	Enterobacter Cloacae Complex
Stephanie Da Silva Rodrigues De Souza	Maeve Donnelly	Uncovering Virulence in the Human Microbiome: A Focus on Virulence Factors in Commensal Bacteria
	Emma Doughty	Genomic Surveillance of Guillain-Barré Syndrome-Associated Genes in Campylobacter Isolates from Non-Human Sources
	Ethan Palacio	Dissemination and Diversity of Antimicrobial Resistance Genes in the Human Microbiome
	Tristan Suarez	Evaluation of Commercial Disinfectant Wipes for Removal of Escherichia coli K-12 from a Non-Porous Acrylic Surface

Neuroscience and Behavior Presentations

Mentor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Annalisa Scimemi	Izabella Czajkowski	Neuronal glutamate transporters encode dopamine co-release with glutamate and GABA
	Baran Mohammadi	Neuronal glutamate transporters limit dopamine release in the striatum
	Peter Oloruntola	Period Genes Reveal Circadian Rhythmicity in Suprachiasmatic Nucleus
Maxwell Turner	Meagan Leung	Visual Fixation Behavior in Drosophila melanogaster

Winner, Glenn L. Bumpus Award for Excellence in Undergraduate Research: ***Meagan Leung***

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

43RD ANNUAL UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCH SYMPOSIUM (CONT'D)
MAY 1, 2026

Cell Biology, Molecular Disease and Therapeutics Presentations

Mentor	Student Presenter	Presentation Title
Andy Berglund and Ting Wang	Sanjida Ahmed	Modified Polycyclic Compound Synthesis and Screening in Myotonic Dystrophy Type 1
Andy Berglund	Humayra Islam Oishi	Potential of Combined Small Molecule Treatment in Myotonic Dystrophy Type 1 (DM1)
Douglas Conklin	Jessica Teague	Alternative Promoter–Driven Kinase Isoforms: Implications for ABL1 Regulation and Cancer Progression
Soma Dash	Diya Mangatt	Med24 Is Required for Normal Feeding Behavior in Zebrafish
Bijan K. Dey	Lemma Khogali	Exploring Gene Expression Signatures in Duchenne Muscular Dystrophy (DMD)
Todd Gray	Jordene Wynter	What's the Message? The Role of Transcription Factor EspM and its Regulation of WhiB6 in Mycobacterial Conjugal Signaling
Melinda Larsen	Julissa Forde	Using antagomirs to knockdown TGFβ1-induced miRNAs driving fibrosis during Myofibroblast Transition
Michelle Lennartz	Ishaan Singh	Role of PKCε in Atherosclerosis explored through Macrophages.
Cara T. Pager	Ethan Krupa	Development of a Zika Virus Single Cell Fluorescent Reporter
Morgan A. Sammons	Parmesh Thakoordial	Dissecting transactivation by the ΔN-specific N-terminal domains of p63 and p73
Yubing Xie	Winnie Ou	Evaluation of Extracellular Matrix (ECM) Changes in Steroid-Induced 3D Glaucoma Models

Winner, Glenn L. Bumpus Award for Excellence in Undergraduate Research: ***Diya Mangatt***

Winner, The Robert Osuna Award for Undergraduate Research in Biochemistry and Molecular Biology: ***Humayra Islam Oishi***

Winner, Departmental Award for Excellence in Undergraduate Research: ***Sanjida Ahmed***



UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

UALBANY BIOLOGY GRADUATE STUDENT AWARDS

Each year, the Department of Biological Sciences at the University at Albany recognizes outstanding graduate students through the Outstanding Teaching Assistant of the Year Award, the David Shub Graduate Student Award for Excellence in RNA Research, and the Professors Peter and Anne Marfey Book Award. We are pleased to announce the recipients of the 2024–2025 Department of Biological Sciences Graduate Student Awards.



Asmar Aliyeva

David Shub Graduate Student Award for Excellence in RNA Research: Asmar Aliyeva

Established by Professor David Shub, this $500 award is presented to a senior graduate student conducting RNA-related research who exemplifies the qualities of David Shub, former faculty member and Chair of Biological Sciences: innovation, motivation, and scholarship. The 2024–2025 recipient is Dr. **Asmar Aliyeva**, a current Postdoctoral Fellow in Dr. Berglund's lab who completed her Ph.D. in the Berglund Lab in May 2026. As a Ph.D. student, she demonstrated exceptional dedication to values set forth by Dr. Shub through her research and scholarly achievements.



Andrew Munoz Gamba

Peter and Anne Marfey Book Award: Andrew Munoz Gamba

Created by Professor Anne Marfey in memory of her late husband, Professor S. Peter Marfey, and supported by Ms. Christina Marfey and Mr. Johan Marfey, this award recognizes a graduate student in Biological Sciences who has demonstrated excellence in biological chemistry. The Marfey Endowment provides a $150 book award. The 2024–2025 recipient is **Andrew Munoz Gamba**, a Ph.D. student in Dr. Cara Pager's lab, in recognition of his outstanding contributions to the field of biochemistry.



Michelle Urman

UAlbany Distinguished Dissertation Award Recipients (2025–2026: Michelle Urman and Asmar Aliyeva)

The Department of Biological Sciences also proudly recognizes two recipients of the University at Albany Distinguished Dissertation Award for 2025–2026.

- Dr. **Michelle Urman** who completed her dissertation under the supervision of Dr. ChangHwan Lee have both been honored for dissertations that demonstrate exceptional originality, rigor, and scholarly impact.; and
- Dr. **Asmar Aliyeva**, whose doctoral research was conducted under the mentorship of Dr. Andrew Berglund



Carlsy Ybanez

Outstanding Teaching Assistant of the Year Award: Carlsy Ybanez

Established in 1995 in memory of Don LaFrancois, this award recognizes graduate student teaching assistants who have earned the respect of students and faculty through their dedication to teaching and commitment to student success. The 2024–2025 recipient is **Carlsy Ybanez**, a member of Dr. Forni's lab, who has consistently demonstrated excellence in the classroom through a strong sense of responsibility, exceptional teaching, and genuine care for students.

Congratulations to all our award recipients on their outstanding achievements!

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

STUDENT HONORS

FINALIST FOR SUNY CHANCELLOR'S DISTINGUISHED PHD DISSERTATION: MAURICE PETROCCIONE



Maurice Petroccione

The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Dr. **Maurice Petroccione** on being named a finalist for the SUNY Chancellor's Distinguished PhD Dissertation Award. This SUNY-wide honor recognizes the most exceptional doctoral dissertations across SUNY's Ph.D.-awarding institutions.

Dr. Petroccione completed his doctoral research in the laboratory of Associate Professor Annalisa Scimemi. His dissertation, "The Multifaceted Role of Glutamate at Excitatory and Inhibitory Synapses," was nominated by University at Albany in recognition of its outstanding scholarly quality and its significance within the field of neuroscience. This achievement demonstrates the strength of University of Albany's graduate research and mentorship programs.

Each year, SUNY graduates approximately 1,200 PhD students across various disciplines including the life and physical sciences plus engineering, social sciences, and the fine arts. The nine SUNY institutions that grant doctoral degrees are each invited to submit one nomination each year for this award. The first-place recipient receives $5,000 to support professional development while up to five finalists are awarded $1,000 each. All awardees are formally recognized by the SUNY Chancellor in celebration of their research accomplishments and SUNY's commitment to supporting excellence.

Dr. Petroccione is currently continuing his research as a postdoctoral fellow in the Scimemi lab.

Again, congratulations to Dr. Petroccione and the Scimemi lab on this outstanding achievement!

STUDENT HONORS

BIOLOGY STUDENT PARMESH THAKOORDIAL EARNS NATIONAL RECOGNITION FOR RESEARCH, SERVICE, AND LEADERSHIP



Parmesh Thakoordial

The Department of Biological Sciences is proud to celebrate the achievements of **Parmesh Thakoordial** whose dedication to scientific research, public service and academic excellence has earned him multiple national honors.

A first-generation college student whose family immigrated from Guyana, Parmesh credits his family's strong belief in education for inspiring his passion for science and medicine. Their support and sacrifices motivated him to pursue a career focused on advancing medical research and improving healthcare in communities that need it most.

At the University at Albany, Parmesh is a double major in Biochemistry and Molecular Biology and Psychology with a minor in Spanish. As an NIH-MARC Fellow, Parmesh currently conducts research in the laboratory of Dr. Morgan Sammons in UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences and the RNA Institute. His work focuses on understanding how changes in genes affect a P63 protein that is required for healthy skin development.

Parmesh 's research experiences go beyond UAlbany. For example, he has completed summer research programs at the David Geffen School of Medicine at UCLA, Yale University through the Amgen Scholars Program, and Harvard Medical School through the Harvard/MIT Early Access to Research Training (HEART) Program. These research experiences gave Parmesh the opportunity to work with scientists while studying heart disease, skin cancer and new methods to treating blood illnesses.

Parmesh 's academic excellence and commitment to public service have earned him several national honors including the Obama-Chesky Scholarship for Public Service, selection to the inaugural Howard Hughes Medical Institute Cech Fellows Program, and recognition as a 2026 Phi Beta Kappa Key into Public Service Scholar. He is also an active UAlbany leader and volunteer by serving in several student organizations and supporting community health programs.

After graduating in 2027, Parmesh plans to pursue an MD/PhD, with the hope to develop new treatments for cardiovascular disease while improving access to care for underserved communities.

The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Parmesh on his outstanding accomplishments. His achievements reflect the impact of undergraduate research, leadership and service and illustrate the University, the College of Arts and Sciences and the Biology Department's commitment to preparing the next generation of healthcare practitioners and researchers.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

EVENTS AND SEMINARS

THE BIOLOGY SEMINAR SERIES

Exploring Scientific Discovery through the Biology Seminar Series

The Department of Biological Sciences at UAlbany hosted a seminar series throughout the 2025–2026 academic year with researchers from across the country. Each week, students, faculty, and alumni attend this weekly seminar series to learn about new discoveries in cell biology and developmental genetics to neuroscience, infectious diseases, microbial biology, and regenerative medicine.



Paul Lemon Ecology Fund Seminar: **Blanca Barquera** (Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute) *Bacterioside Fitness in the Human Gut: An Energy Metabolism Perspective*



Martin Darvas (University of Washington School of Medicine) *Targeting Multiple Processes of Aging as a Novel Intervention of Dementia*



Martin Horvath (University at Utah) *Mechanism and Evolution of the DNA Base Excision Repair Enzyme MutY*



Julian Meeks (University of Rochester Medical Center) *Making Sense of the Mess: Detection, Organization, and Integration of Social Chemosensory Information by the Mouse Accessory Olfactory System*



Kevin Monahan (Rutgers University) *Testis expressed gene 15 is required for neuronal diversity in the mouse olfactory system*



Tyler Sizemore (Yale University) *The Neurobiology of Innate Feeding Behaviors*



Thomas Bartlet (University at Albany) *Bends and Turns: Re-assessment of the Roles of Cell Envelope Geometry in Cell Division*



Sergei Djuranovic (Brown University) *Gene specific ASO-Mediated Upregulation of Protein Synthesis and New Methods to Isolate and Follow Ribosomes and Translation Complexes*



Mustafa Khokha (Yale University) *Patient Driven Gene Discovery Defines New Pathways Regulating Development: Metabolism, Hif1a, Wnt*



Susana Mingote (City University of New York) *New Insights into Memory Decline with Aging by Investigating Entorhinal Dopamine-Glutamate Input*



Jon Paczkowski (NYDOH Wadsworth Center) *Timing is Everything: How Pseudomonas aeruginosa Makes and Breaks a Quorum*



Purushothama Rao Tata (Duke University) *Transitional Cell States: Drivers of Tissue Sculpting in Regeneration and Disease*

The series which was organized Dr. **Ing-Nang Wang** took place every Thursday afternoon in the D'Ambra Auditorium at UAlbany's Life Science Research Building. The Biology Department looks forward to welcoming faculty, students, and alumni back for the 2026–2027 seminar series.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

EVENTS AND SEMINARS

12TH ANNUAL LIFE AT THE INTERFACE OF SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING (LISE) LECTURE SERIES

LIFE AT THE INTERFACE OF SCIENCE + ENGINEERING lecture series



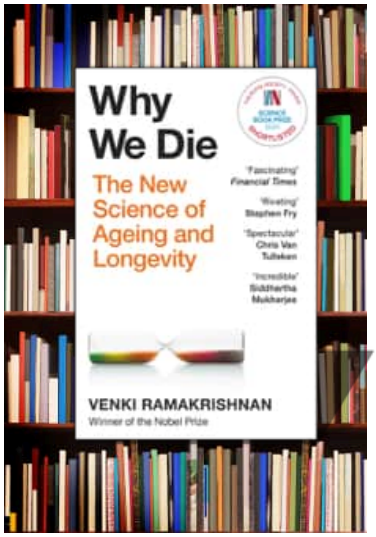
Nobel Prize Winner **Venki Ramakrishnan**
2026 LISE featured lecturer and
author of Why We Die

The University at Albany hosted a lecture by Nobel Prize Winner Venki Ramakrishnan from the MRC Laboratory of Molecular Biology at Cambridge University open to the public where Dr. Ramakrishnan discussed his book "Why We Die: The New Science of Aging & the Quest for Immortality," a New York Times Bestseller shortlisted for the Royal Society Science Book Prize, at the University at Albany on March 31, 2025.

Dr. Ramakrishnan received the 2009 Nobel Prize in Chemistry for uncovering the structure of the ribosome. He runs the Ramakrishnan Lab at the MRC Laboratory of Molecular Biology in Cambridge, UK.

His book describes how cutting-edge efforts to extend lifespan by altering our natural biology raise profound questions: Although we might not like it, does death serve a necessary biological purpose? And how can we increase our chances of living long, healthy and fulfilled lives? As science advances, we have much to gain. But might we also have much to lose?

Dr. Ramakrishnan's lecture was followed with lively audience Q&A session in which UAlbany faculty, students, and members of the public were given an opportunity to explore many of the ideas posited in the book.



The *Life at the Interface of Science and Engineering (LISE)* lecture series is endowed by UAlbany Professor Marlene Belfort and her husband, RPI Professor Georges Belfort, and fosters interdisciplinary collaboration between life sciences and engineering.

The LISE series was created to bridge research across UAlbany and Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute (RPI) by bringing pioneering scientists to the Capital Region.

Previous LISE lectures have included luminaries from many fields in science and engineering, including five Nobel Prize Winners: Thomas Cech, University of Colorado (2016); Frances Arnold, Caltech (2018); Jennifer A Doudna, UC Berkeley (2021); David Baker, University of Washington (2023); Phillip A. Sharp, MIT (2025).

With this lecture series, the Belforts emphasize the importance of such interdisciplinary efforts in translating fundamental science into lifesaving technologies and hope the lecture inspires students and faculty alike to engage deeply across disciplines to drive innovation.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

CENTRAL PARK FIVE CASE USED TO INTRODUCE HIGH SCHOOL STUDENTS TO FORENSIC SCIENCE



Stephen Hogan



Ryan Thurman

UAlbany Brings Real-World Criminal Justice Case to High School Students

Close to 300 high school students learned about the Central Park Five case and explored how forensic science, psychology, and criminal justice can influence investigations and legal outcomes by attending the June 5, 2026, event either in person at UAlbany or by Zoom.

The Central Park Five case involved the assault and rape of a women who was jogging in Central Park in Manhattan, New York City on April 19, 1989. Six teenagers were initially charged in connection with the incident and were also accused of involvement in other assaults that occurred that same night. The case drew national attention and increased public concern about crime in New York City. After the convictions were later overturned, the case came to be seen as an example of racial profiling, discrimination, and inequities in the criminal justice system and media coverage.

This event was organized by UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences and School of Criminal Justice as part of the UAlbany in the High School Program. Throughout the academic year, UAlbany faculty partnered with local forensic science instructors to help students examine the case that occurred in and understand its lasting impact on the criminal justice system.

Students had the opportunity to hear from Steven Lopez who was wrongfully implicated in the case as a teenager, and his attorney Eric Shapiro Renfroe. Their presentation provided a firsthand perspective on the personal and legal challenges associated with wrongful convictions and the long-lasting effects they can have on individuals and their families.

Dr. **Ryan Thurman**, Director of UAlbany's Forensic Biology Program discussed how forensic evidence was interpreted during the investigation and how errors in evidence evaluation and witness statements contributed to the case. He also introduced students to career opportunities in forensic science and biology and led tours of UAlbany's forensic biology laboratories.

Visiting Assistant Professor **Stephen Hogan** discussed the concept of cognitive dissonance which occurs when a person holds two conflicting beliefs, ideas, or pieces of information at the same time. This internal conflict can influence how people interpret evidence and make decisions and may lead them to favor information that supports what they already believe while overlooking information that does not. His presentation emphasized the importance of staying objective during investigations and carefully evaluating all available evidence.

The event provided students with an opportunity to connect classroom learning with an actual case that continues to shape discussions about justice, evidence, and investigative practices. By bringing together experts in forensic science, criminal justice, and law, this outreach event demonstrated the important role that science and critical thinking play in the seeking justice.

Students attending the event in person also explored various UAlbany's academic programs and the career pathways available to graduates in biology, forensic science, and criminal justice.

This outreach program was made possible through the collaboration of UAlbany faculty, staff, administrators, and community partners. Special thanks to **John McCluskey, Julie Novkov, Nina Santiago, Sridar Chittur, Jeanette Altarriba, Steven Lopez, Eric Shapiro Renfroe, Mindy Larsen, Victoria Gellatly, Pauline Carrico, Stephen Hogan**, and **Ryan Thurman** whose efforts helped create and deliver this successful outreach program for high school students.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

EVENTS AND SEMINARS

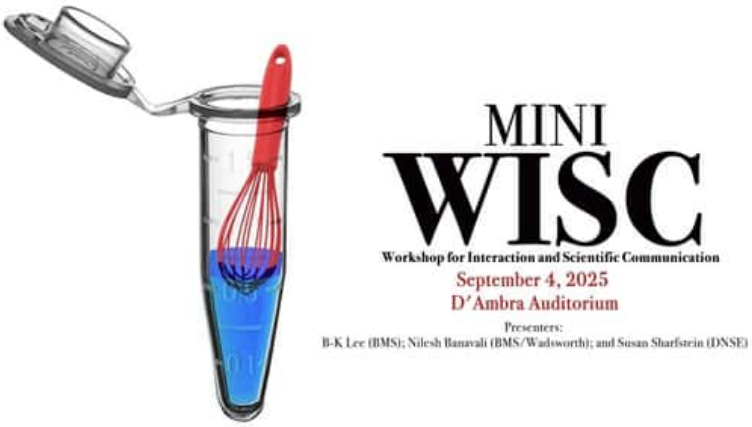
WORKSHOP FOR INTERACTION AND SCIENTIFIC COMMUNICATION (WISC): A CELEBRATION OF COLLABORATION AND DISCOVERY



Marlene Belfort



Paolo Forni



On Thursday, September 4, 2025, the UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences and the Life Sciences hosted the Mini Workshop for Interaction and Scientific Communication at the Life Sciences Research Building (LSRB) D'Ambra Auditorium.

The event, which was organized by Dr. **Marlene Belfort** and Dr. **Paolo Forni**, drew 106 participants that included graduate students, faculty, postdocs, and scientists from the UAlbany Departments of Biological Sciences, Chemistry, and Psychology, the College of Nanotechnology, Science and Engineering, the RNA Institute plus the Neural Stem Cell Institute, the New York State Department of Health, and the Department of Biomedical Sciences (BMS). This workshop was designed to promote collaboration and share ideas among scientists at different stages of their careers and across various disciplines.

Dr. Jeanette Altarriba Professor and Dean of the College of Arts and Sciences (CAS) together with Dr. Marlene Belfort, Distinguished Professor of Biology and Senior Advisor to the RNA Institute provided the opening remarks for the workshop.

The event combined short research presentations plus a poster session that showcased the research being conducted by UAlbany faculty and students. Additionally, the workshop featured three invited speakers with each offering unique insights from their field of study:

- Dr. **Susan T. Sharfstein**, Professor of UAlbany's Nanoscale Science and Engineering opened the workshop with a talk that bridged engineering and life sciences. As a trained Biochemical Engineer, Dr. Sharfstein's work focuses on Chinese hamster ovary cell biomanufacturing, regenerative medicine, and microphysiological systems such as organoids that are combined with semiconductor-based measurement systems.
- Dr. **Nilesh Banavali**, a research scientist at the Wadsworth Center with a background in pharmaceutical sciences and postdoctoral positions at Cornell Medical College and the University of Chicago shared his expertise in molecular dynamics simulations, free energy estimation, structure prediction, and cryo-electron microscopy.
- Dr. **Bum-Kyu Lee**, Assistant Professor in the Department of Biomedical Sciences at UAlbany, gave a presentation on gene regulation and stem cell biology. Dr. Lee's current research investigates key regulators of trophoblast differentiation using stem cell and organoid models to understand placental development.

At this time, UAlbany, CAS and the Department of Biological Sciences wish to express their sincere gratitude to Drs. Paolo Forni and Marlene Belfort for their countless hours and support in organizing this very successful event.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY INTERNATIONAL WOMEN'S DAY EVENT



Cathleen Schiraldi



Sarah Grunow

Biology Alumna Cathleen Schiraldi and Others Share Experiences from their STEM Careers

Women in science, technology, engineering, arts, and mathematics (STEAM) shared their personal and professional journeys during an International Women's Day event held March 6, 2026, at UAlbany's Life Sciences Research Building.

The event brought together students, faculty, and alumni to discuss the diverse career paths and experiences of women in STEM-related fields. It was organized by the student chapter of the Society of Women Engineers and Women in Science and Health with the support from UAlbany's College of Nanotechnology, Science, and Engineering.

Speakers included UAlbany Department of Biological Sciences PhD alumna **Cathleen Schiraldi** who is currently a staff scientist at Regeneron. Dr. Schiraldi discussed her transition from graduate school in molecular biology to industry research, and more importantly the challenges of early career changes and balancing professional and personal responsibilities.

The keynote address was delivered by **Sarah Grunow** who earned her MS and PhD in physics from UAlbany and is now director of Package & Test at GlobalFoundries. She also discussed balancing a demanding career with family responsibilities and the importance of adapting to life's changing demands.

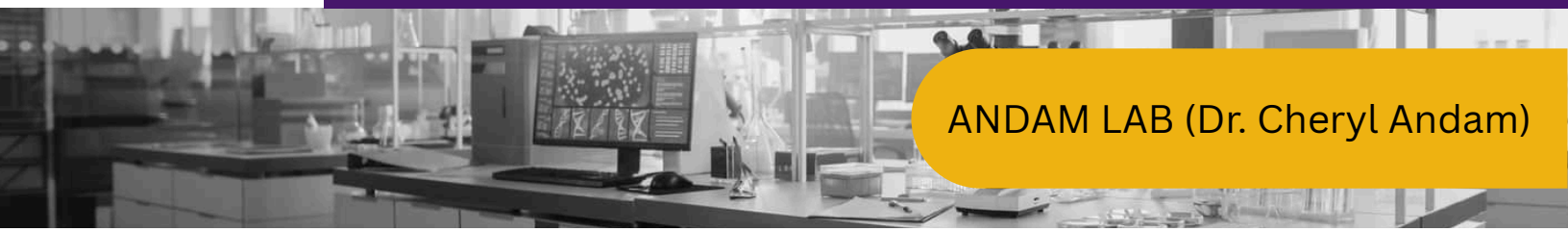


A panel discussion featuring professionals from industry, academia, and technology explored career development, self-confidence, and the importance of setting boundaries and seeking support. Panelists emphasized the value of mentorship and professional networking in helping individuals to adjust and move forward with their STEM careers.



UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS



ANDAM LAB (Dr. Cheryl Andam)

Publications

- Souza SSR, Berlus MJ, **Andam CP**. 2026. *Diversity and evolution of leukotoxin operons in Staphylococcus aureus*. mSystems 11. PMCID: PMC13185589. DOI: 10.1128/msystems.01735-25.
- Sánchez-Osuna M, Buiatte ABG, Wang R, Gasch O, Martin IW, **Andam CP**, Pich OQ. 2026. *mGem: Population genomics of Staphylococcus aureus bacteremia and the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic*. mBio 17. PMCID: PMC13170315. DOI: 10.1128/mbio.03665-25.
- Costa LRM, Marmion M, Buiatte ABG, **Andam CP**. 2026. *Five-decade global expansion of Staphylococcus argenteus ST2250 shapes antimicrobial resistance dynamics*. NPJ Antimicrobials and Resistance 4:14. PMCID: PMC12946336. DOI: 10.1038/s44259-026-00188-6.
- Choudhury ST, **Andam CP**. 2026. *Genome-wide co-occurrence patterns link mobile genetic elements, antimicrobial resistance and defense systems in Pseudomonas aeruginosa*. BMC Genomics 27:226. PMCID: PMC12922284. DOI: 10.1186/s12864-026-12585-2.
- Choudhury ST, Lindberg SK, **Andam CP**. 2026. *Genomic variants distinguish Pseudomonas aeruginosa from cystic fibrosis lungs and bloodstream infection*. BMC Infectious Diseases 26:243. PMCID: PMC12870028. DOI: 10.1186/s12879-025-12501-1.
- Hariharan J, **Andam CP**, Buckley DH. 2025. *Biogeographical and phylogenetic constraints on horizontal gene transfer and genome evolution in Streptomyces*. Microbiology Spectrum 14. PMCID: PMC12889140. DOI: 10.1101/2025.09.05.674406.
- Buiatte ABG, Marmion M, Choudhury ST, Ikhimiukor OO, Wirth SE, Musser KA, Mingle LA, **Andam CP**. 2026. *Genomic epidemiology reveals statewide dispersal of clinical Shiga toxin-producing Escherichia coli and their antimicrobial resistome.* Microbiology Spectrum 14. PMCID: PMC12772303. DOI: 10.1128/spectrum.00956-25.
- Muller H, **Andam CP**. 2025. *Diversification of the staphylococcal cassette chromosome through distinct mechanisms of horizontal transfer.* Genome Biology and Evolution 17. PMCID: PMC12648241. DOI: 10.1093/gbe/evaf214.
- Muller H, Ikhimiukor OO, Montoya-Giraldo M, Piper KR, Marmion M, Blumerman SL, Mingle L, Wirth SE, Musser KA, Wolfgang WJ, **Andam CP**. 2025. *Genetic exchange networks bridge mobile DNA vehicles in the bacterial pathogen Listeria monocytogenes.* Nature Communications 16:9723. PMCID: PMC12586434. DOI: 10.1038/s41467-025-64743-x.
- Ikhimiukor OO, Montoya-Giraldo M, Souza SSR, Akintayo IJ, Zac Soligno NI, Marmion M, Eckhardt E, Carreiro N, Workman AA, Martin IW, **Andam CP**. 2025. *Dissemination dynamics of colistin resistance genes mcr-9 and mcr-10 across diverse Inc plasmid backbones.* Communications Medicine 5:399. PMCID: PMC12462442. DOI: 10.1038/s43856-025-01109-w.
- Souza SSR, Piper KR, Ikhimiukor OO, Marcovici MM, Zac Soligno NI, Harmon AJ, Eckhardt EM, Carreiro N, Workman AA, Martin IW, **Andam CP**. 2025. *Variants of beta-lactamase-encoding genes are disseminated by multiple genetically distinct lineages of bloodstream Escherichia coli.* Communications Medicine 5:260. PMCID: PMC12216325. DOI: 10.1038/s43856-025-00972-x.

Awards

- Dr. Andam received the President's Excellence Award in Research and Creative Activities (ERCA) in March 2026 in recognition of her research on horizontal gene transfer in microbial evolution and antibiotic resistance.
- Dr. Andam received a renewed R35 Maximizing Investigators' Research Award (MIRA) from the National Institute of General Medical Sciences (NIGMS) of the National Institutes of Health (NIH) in June 2026. The award provides more than $2 million to support her research on the mechanisms, causes, and consequences of bacterial recombination from 2026–2031.
- Dr. Andam received the Faculty Research Award Program–Category A (FRAP-A) in February 2026 and the Bridge Funding Award in March 2026 from the Office of the Vice President for Research and Economic Development (OVPRED).

Recent Graduates

- **Samara T. Choudhury** graduated from the Department of Biological Sciences Ph.D. Program in January 2026.

Promotions and Appointments

- Dr. Andam was appointed Scientific Director of the Life Sciences Research Initiative in September 2025.

Other Accomplishments

- Ph.D. student **Kali Christopher** successfully passed Qualifying Examination I in May 2026.
- Ph.D. student **Bryce Chong** successfully passed Qualifying Examination II in June 2026.
- Ph.D. candidate **Manuela Montoya-Giraldo** successfully defended her dissertation in June 2026.
- Postdoctoral scientists **Samantha Lindberg** and **Héloïse Muller** completed their appointments in Dr. Andam's laboratory in June 2026 and July 2025, respectively. Dr. Lindberg accepted a position at the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) in Atlanta, Georgia, and Dr. Muller joined the Institut de Biologie de l'École Normale Supérieure in Paris, France, as a research scientist.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS



BEGLEY LAB (Dr. Thomas Begley)

Publications

- Ghanegolmohammadi F, Ohnuki S, Byrne S, Raman R, **Begley TJ**, Dedon PC. *Synonymous codon usage defines functional gene families.* BMC Biol. 2026 Jan 27.doi: 10.1186/s12915-026-02505-x. PMID: 41593609. DOI: 10.1186/s12915-026-02505-x
- Zhou H, Li Y, Zhang J, Wang L, Zheng YY, Wu C, **Begley TJ**, Sheng J, Wang R.*Nature-Inspired Chemical Probes for Labeling tRNAs Containing 2-Thiouridine.* Chembiochem. 2025 Nov 8;26(21):e202500453. doi: 10.1002/cbic.202500453. Epub 2025 Sep 23. PMID: 40985306.
- Dansereau SJ, Shekhtman A, Genovese S, Collevecchio C, Fiorito S, **Begley TJ**, Epifano F, Sheng J. *An Oxyprenylated Phenylpropanoid Pharmacologic Scaffold for Sel Inhibition.* Chembiochem. 2025 Aug 22;26(15):e202500280. doi:10.1002/cbic.202500280. Epub 2025 Jul 9. PMID: 40540237.
- Sun, J, Wu, J, Yuan, Fan, L, Chua, W.L. P, Ling, Y. H. S., Balamkundu, S., Chay, H.S.S., **Begley, T.J.**, Valérie de Cr écy -Lag ar d, V., Dziergowska, A., Dedon, P.C. *tRNA modification profiling reveals epitranscriptome regulatory networks in Pseudomonas aeruginosa. Nucleic Acid Research.* 2025 July 19;53(14). https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/40716780/
- Chittrakanwong, J, Chen, R, Wu, J, Demott, MS, Sun, J, Phatinuwat, K, Jaroensuk, J, Atichartpongku,l S, Mongkolsuk, S, **Begley, T.J.**, Dedon P.C., Fuangthong M. *5-Methyluridine is Ubiquitous in Pseudomonas aeruginosa tRNA and Modulates Antimicrobial Resistance and Virulence.* J Mol Biol. 2025 Aug 15;437(16):169020.https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/40055058/

Awards

- **Nate Beam**, NIH sponsored RNA Fellowship, Awarded July 1, 2026 to June 30, 2027
- **Chetna Mathur**, Outstanding Research Poster at the 2026 Upstate NY RNA Symposium, March 2026
- **Safi Khiati**, Travel Award, RNA Therapeutics Meeting at UMass, Worcester, June 2026
- **Dylan Ehrbar**, Graduate Pathway for Scholars Honorable Mention, Feb 2026
- **Dylan Ehrbar**, Best Poster for Research, RNA Day, University at Albany, Aug 2025
- **Humphrey Omeoga**, PhD awarded, "Wobble Uridine tRNA Writers Regulate Response Systems with Distinct Codon Signatures", April 2026
- **Cady Roselli**, Undergraduate researcher in Begley Lab, BS in Biochemistry and Molecular Biology awarded in May 2026.Accepted to the PhD program in Biomedical Engineering, Stony Brook University, SUNY
- **Cady Roselli**, Best Poster Presenter in the Summer RNA Institute Bioinformatics Program, Aug 2025.

Other Accomplishments

New Grants in 2025-2026

- Principal Investigator (PIs: Begley & Dedon, R01ES038107)
  Project: *Epitranscriptomic and Epigenetic Loops Driving the Response to Naphthalene (NA)*
  Source: National Institute of Environmental Health Sciences , NIH
  Time Period: 4/01/2026 – 03/31/2031
  Total Funding: $3,929,322
  Successful completion of the proposed work will mark and define epigenetic and epitranscriptomic regulatory loops driving the response to NA and wood smoke in mouse lungs and livers. It will also determine if RNA modifications are regulated during live fire training exercises when firefighters are exposed to wood smoke.
- Co-Principal Investigator (PI: Xiaoling Zhang form Boston University, R01AG096052)
  Project: *tRNA modifications regulating mitochondrial function and the mitochondrial proteome AD/ADRD*
  Source: Boston University / NIA-NIH
  Time Period: 9/15/2025 – 6/30/2030
  Total Funding $431, 601
  The proposed studies test the role of synonymous codon "silent mutations" as drivers of pathobiology in neurodegenerative diseases.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS

BEGLEY LAB (Dr. Thomas Begley)

Other Accomplishments

New Grants in 2025-2026

- Principal Investigator (PIs: Dedon, Sobol, Lee, Nagel & Begley, R01AG090585)
  Project: *A systems-level analysis of DNA damage and repair in senescence, aging and cancer*
  Source: National Institute on Aging, NIH
  Time Period: 06/01/2026 – 02/28/2031
  Total Funding: $3,994,750. $3,365,498
  The major goals of this grant are to characterize the adductome in modes of aging. DNA repair knockout lines will be utilized to identify new substrates and adducts that cause replication stress. Transcriptional markers of DNA adduct stress will also be identified.
- Co-Principal Investigator (PI: Ben Wolozon and Peter Dedon from Boston University and MIT, R01AG095773)
  Project: *tRNA Epitranscriptome and Translational Dysfunction in ADRD*
  Source: National Institute on Aging, NIH
  Time Period: 09/15/2025 – 5/31/2020
  Total Funding: $613,998
  The proposed studies test if codon usage bias is present in aggregated proteomes and whether codon re-engineering can affect the solubility of specific proteins implicate in the of pathobiology in neurodegenerative diseases.

Renewed Grants in 2025 – 2021

- Principal Investigator (PI: Begley, 2T32GM132066)
  Project: *RNA Science and Technology in Health and Disease*
  Source: National Institute of General Medical Sciences, NIH
  Time Period: 07/01/2019 - 06/30/2030, renewal scored a 23
  Total Funding: $1,177,380 + $2,067,917
  The overall goal of the RNA Fellows program is to rigorously train graduate students for careers in science and technology companies, science communication organizations, public service or academia. The training grant brings together investigators and students from the Departments of Biological Sciences, Chemistry and Biomedical Sciences at UAlbany, Wadsworth Center and Nanobiosciences.



BELFORT LAB (Dr. Marlene Belfort)

Publications

- Begley, T.and **Belfort, M.** *RNA is key to the dark matter of the genome – scientists are sequencing it to illuminate human health and disease.* The Conversation (2026) https://doi.org/10.64628/AAI.nqwjkagea
- Lennon, C.W., Callahan, B.P., and **Belfort , M.** Chapter in Integrative Theory of Evolution-Aspects and Insights (2026). *Inteins: Emerging Regulatory Roles and Their Exaptation for Hedgehog Signaling* 447-462. https://doi.org/10.1093/gbe/evw253

Awards

- 2025 Association for Women in Science's Zenith Award Zenith Award for innovative scientific achievements and commitment to workplace diversity and support of young researchers.

Presentations

- 2025 Meet the Microbiologist. American Society for Microbiology https://asm.org/podcasts/mtm/episodes/unraveling-introns-and-expectations-with-marlene-b.
- 2025 From Lab to Literature. American Society for Microbiology (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JeF-N4WABq4)
- 2026 Graduate Workers in Science (GWIS) University of Rochester, Rochester, NY
- 2026 Being a Post-doc Has Always Been Rough. UAlbany Postdoctoral Network. Albany, NY
- 2026 UA Phi Sigma Rho, STEM Sorority, UAlbany NY
- 2026 Navigating Scientific Challenges. RPI Training grant retreat. Troy, NY
- 2026 Book talk to Biochemistry class, Gustavio Adolphus, St. Peter, MN
- 2026 AWIS Book Club. Association for Women in Science (AWIS)

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS

Other Accomplishments

- Biology co-sponsored the Life at the Interface of Science and Engineering lectures with RPI and the NYS Writers Institute. The lectures, delivered by Nobel Laureate Venki Ramakrishnan, University of Cambridge, were supported by RPI and UAlbany through endowments from Georges and Marlene Belfort, by the Biology Department, the RNA Institute and the NYS Writers Institute.

BELFORT LAB (Dr. Marlene Belfort)



DASH LAB (Dr. Soma Dash)

Publications

- **Dash S.**, Rettig J., Gogol M., Trainor P., *Vascular Patterning Shapes Intramembranous Ossification via the HIF1α–VEGF Axis*, Accepted for publication in Journal of Dental Research

Recent Graduates

- **Aminata Fofana**, M.S., MCDN M.S. Program



FORNI LAB (Dr. Paolo Forni)

Publications

- Mathias NA, Dolphin NM, LeFever NM, Amato E Jr, Ybanez C, Ruquet A, **Forni PE.** (2026).Canopy1/Cnpy1 is required for proper V2R processing and transport; its loss impairs the function and circuit organization of basal/V2R vomeronasal sensory neurons. Development. 2026 Jun 15;153(12). doi: 10.1242/dev.205386. Epub 2026 Jun 19. PubMed PMID: 42299035.
- Amato E, Call MV, LeFever NM, Aviles-Carlos M, Dolphin NM, **Forni PE.** (2026) Goofy/123Cre Lineage Tracing Differentiates Olfactory and Vomeronasal Neurons from GnRH-1 and Terminal Nerve Neurons During Neuronal Migration and Reveals Additional Olfactory Placode-Derived Cells in the Brain. Dev Dyn. 2026 Jun 15;. doi: 10.1002/dvdy.70164. [Epub ahead of print] PubMed PMID: 42294802.
- Lafrican JJ, Parra KE, Rybka KA, Ladison JM, Hellman NA, Amato E Jr, Taroc EZM, Kolaib AS, Thayer R, Sakeria AA, Meunier P, Zuloaga KL, **Forni PE**, Justice NJ, Zuloaga DG. (2026). Sex differences in corticotropin-releasing factor receptor-2α expressing neurons in acutely stressed mice. Horm Behav. Feb 28;180:105904. doi: 10.1016/j.yhbeh.2026.105904. Epub ahead of print. PMID: 41764876.
- Mathias N, Dolphin N, Ruquet A, **Forni PE.** (2025). Canopy1/Cnpy1 is required for proper V2R processing and transport; its loss impairs the function and circuit organization of basal/V2R vomeronasal sensory neurons. bioRxiv [Preprint]. 2025 Nov 19:2025.11.19.689260. doi: 10.1101/2025.11.19.689260. PMID: 41332711; PMCID: PMC12667741.
- Taroc, E. Z. M.[+], Amato, E.[+], Semon, A.[+], Dolphin, N.[+], Beck, B., Belin, S., Poitelon, Y., & **Forni, P. E.** (2025). Shared Lineage, Distinct Outcomes: Yap and Taz Loss Differentially Impact Schwann and Olfactory Ensheathing Cell Development Without Disrupting GnRH-1 Migration. Glia 2025. https://doi.org/10.1002/glia.70057

Awards

- Dr. Forni was promoted to Full Professor.
- Dr. Forni was nominated for the 2025–26 Chancellor's Award for Excellence in Scholarship and Creative Activities.
- **Nicolas Lane** received the Mafrey Award.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS

FORNI LAB (Dr. Paolo Forni)

Recent Graduates

- **Enrico Amato** – M.S., MCDN Ph.D. Program (Thesis Supervisor), Summer 2025
- **Charisse Martin** – M.S., MCDN M.S. Program (Thesis Supervisor), Summer 2025
- **Alexis Semon** – M.S., MCDN M.S. Program (Thesis Supervisor), Summer 2025

Presentations

- Dr. Forni co-organized the Mini WISC symposium series with Dr. Cheryl Andam (Fall 2025 and Spring 2026).
- Dr. Forni co-organized the ECRO 2025 symposium, "Vomeronasal Organ: Development, Function, and Future Perspectives," in Bilbao, Spain, with Prof. Jean-François Cloutier (McGill University).

Other Accomplishments

- Mini WISC will return for Fall 2026.
- Dr. Forni continues to lead international collaborations advancing research on olfactory and vomeronasal system development.



Dr. Christine Gervasi

Awards

- Recognized as Distinguished Nominee for Ember Award



LARSEN LAB (Dr. Melinda Larsen)

Publications

- Contreras J, Vyas B, Ryabchykov O, **Larsen M**, Gildener-Leapman N, Bocklitz T, Popp J, Lednev IK. 2025. *ATR-FTIR spectroscopy of saliva and machine learning as a screening test for Sjögren's disease*. Analytical Chemistry 97(47):26034–26044. DOI: 10.1021/acs.analchem.5c04238.
- Ramesh P, Castracane J, **Larsen M**, Nelson DA, Sharfstein ST, Xie Y. 2025. C*ryoelectrospun elastin-alginate scaffolds support in vitro 3D epithelial-stromal cocultures for salivary tissue engineering.* Gels 11(12):998. DOI: 10.3390/gels11120998.
- Ramesh P, Pena R, Morrissey JM, Moskwa N, Tubbesing K, Zhang X, Nelson D, Castracane J, Khmaladze A, Sharfstein ST, **Larsen M**, Xie Y. 2025. *Cryoelectrospun elastin-alginate scaffolds as potential cell delivery vehicles for mesenchymal stromal cell therapy.* Scientific Reports 15(1):19847. DOI: 10.1038/s41598-025-03822-x.
- **Larsen M,** Nelson D, Kwon HR, Peters SB, Kenney J, Gellatly V, Bogdanov P, Duffy C, Sood R, Chittur S. 2026. *Overview of Transcriptomic Approaches to Salivary Gland Biology and Regeneration. In: Salivary Gland Development and Regeneration: Advances in Research and Clinical Approaches to Functional Regeneration*, 2nd ed. Edited by Seunghee Cha. Springer International, Switzerland. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-032-07458-4.

UAlbany
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS

LARSEN LAB (Dr. Melinda Larsen)

Awards

- Dr. Larsen was promoted to the rank of Distinguished Professor.
- Dr. Larsen received the Research and Service Award from the RNA Institute at the 2026 RNA Retreat.
- Dr. Larsen was recognized as one of the 2026 20 Outstanding Women in the Capital District, an honor presented by B95.5 and Hannaford Supermarkets.

Recent Graduates

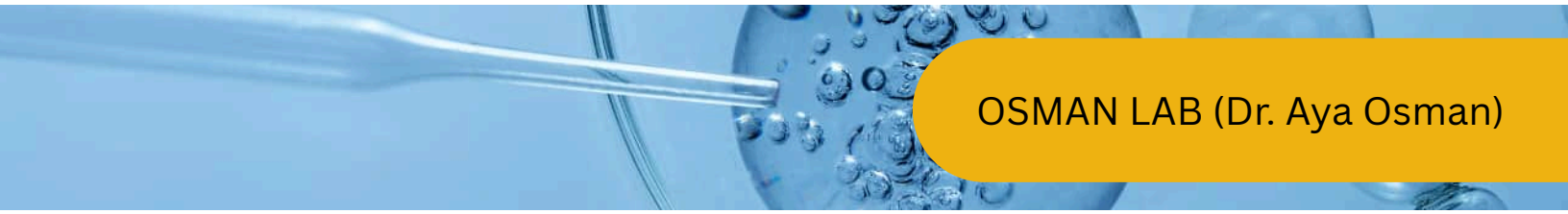
- **Joey Tavarez** graduated from the Department of Biological Sciences Ph.D. Program in May 2026.

Presentations

- Dr. Larsen presented her research at the Upstate RNA Symposium in March 2026 and at the International Association for Dental, Oral, and Craniofacial Research (IADR) Annual Meeting in San Diego, California, in March 2026.

Other Accomplishments

- **Sarah Peters**, Ph.D., Assistant Professor at The Ohio State University, received a National Institutes of Health (NIH) R01 research grant.
- **Matthew Koslow**, Ph.D., accepted a new position as Laboratory Manager at the NYU Tandon School of Engineering.



OSMAN LAB (Dr. Aya Osman)

Publications

- Fricker, L., **Osman, A**., Gupta, A., Gomes, I., Devi, L. A. (2025). *Antidepressants and the endogenous opioid system.* (4 ed.,) 242, pp. 117392. Oxford: Biochemical Pharmacology. https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/41072817/.
- Gupta, A., Gomes, I., Sierra, S., **Osman, A**., Devi, L. (2025). *Endothelin-converting enzyme 2 regulates ê opioid receptor trafficking and function.* (12 ed.,) 392, pp. 103750. Bethesda, MD: The Journal of Pharmacology and Experimental Therapeutics. https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/41205376/.

Presentations

- “Epigenetic Mechanisms Linking Acetate to Transcriptional and Social Behavior Changes in a Genetic Model of Autism Spectrum Disorder" Dylan Baker, MSc Student RNA Symposium 04.16.2026
- "Epigenetic Mechanisms by Which Acetate Rescues Social Deficits and Alters Transcription in Prefrontal Cortex of Shank3-Deficient Mice" Chenaya Soulouque, Undergraduate Student. SUNY Undergraduate Research Conference. 04.24.2026
- “Novel Uses for GLP-1 Agonists and Neuropeptide-Directed Therapeutics to Treat Substance Use Disorder” Aya Osman, Panel Member, Symposium on Substance Use Research (SOSUR), 11.05.2025
- “Exploring Epigenetic and Neuroimmune Mechanisms of Gut-Brain Signaling in Genetic Mouse models of Autism Spectrum Disorder” Aya Osman, Lurie Center for Autism, Harvard Medical School 09.24.2025
- "Navigating the Tenure Track while staying true to yourself" Aya Osman , Panel Member. Stories of Women in Neuroscience Symposium at Society for Neuroscience 11.15.2025

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS



PAGER LAB (Dr. Cara Pager

Publications

- Publication: Badu, P.; González, E.T.C.; **Pager, C.T.** *Cellular Responses to Flavivirus Infections: Stress Signaling at the Crossroads of Host Defense and Virus Infection*. Viruses 2026, 18, 748. https://doi.org/10.3390/v18070748

Awards

- **Nurat Affinnih** received a travel award from the American Society for Virology

Recent Graduates

- **Elianna Cruz González** graduated with a M.S. and is now starting UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences MCDN Ph.D. program

Presentations

- Andrew Muñoz Gamba, Alexander Ciota, and **Cara T. Pager**. *Phenotypic and Genotypic Signatures of Adaptation of Zika Virus After Serial Passaging in Mosquito and Mammalian Hosts*. American Society for Virology Annual Conference. Minneapolis, MN. July 27-30, 2026.
- Nurat Affinih, Shawn Gianola and **Cara T. Pager**. *Investigation of Ilhéus virus infection in mosquito and mammalian cell lines*. American Society for Virology Annual Conference. Minneapolis, MN. July 27-30, 2026.



REDDY LAB (Dr. Kalak Reddy)

Presentations

- **Nick Lane** (PhD student) was recently named an RNA Fellow and presented a talk titled *Investigating the spliceosome as a modifier of congenital myotonic dystrophy* at the New York State Muscle network meeting at the Sloan Kettering Institute in NYC on February 16th 2026.
- **Naa Adade** (Joint PhD Student with Gaby Fuchs) presented a talk titled *Inosine misincorporation into mRNA triggers the integrated stress response* at the Annual Buffalo RNA Symposium in Buffalo NY on June 16th 2026.

Recent Graduates

- **Damini Devpura** graduated with a Master's this May 2026. The title of her thesis was *Development of an Inducible Cellular Model for Myotonic Dystrophy Type 2 (DM2)*

UALBANY

Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY LAB RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS



SCIMEMI LAB (Dr. Annalisa Scimemi)

Publications

- Melone M, Di Palma M, **Scimemi A,** Conti F. 2026. *Organization of Astrocytic GLT-1 at Cortical Inhibitory Synapses.* Glia 74(8). DOI: 10.1002/glia.70180. PMID: 42252583.
- Petroccione MA, Melone M, Rathwell TJ, Dwivedi N, Grienberger C, Conti F, **Scimemi A.** 2026. *An unsuspected physiological role for mGluRIII glutamate receptors in hippocampal area CA1*. Cell Reports 45(6):117388. DOI: 10.1016/j.celrep.2026.117388. PMID: 42207645.
- Oliveira JF, Agarwal A, Beckervordersandforth R, Curreli S, Denizot A, Dulla C, Enger R, Goda Y, Goshen I, Holt MG, Nimmerjahn A, Perea G, **Scimemi A**, Henneberger C. 2026. *The multiple scales of astrocytic functional units.* Nature Neuroscience 29(6):1279–1292. DOI: 10.1038/s41593-026-02308-x. PMID: 42204000.
- Darvas M, Cook DG, **Scimemi A.** 2026. *Decoding Alzheimer's Disease One Cell Class at a Time.* Cellular and Molecular Neurobiology 46(1):52. DOI: 10.1007/s10571-026-01685-y. PMID: 41667797.

Awards

- Undergraduate researcher **Baran Mohammadi** received the 2026 MINERVA Sorrell Chesin Research Award.



TURNER LAB (Dr. Maxwell Turner)

Publications

- ·Mickels, Chloe A., and **Maxwell H. Turner.** 2026. *How Neural Feedback Enables Flexible Visual Processing in Drosophila*. Trends in Neurosciences. 49(1): 63–75.



UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

THOMAS BEGLEY'S RESEARCH ADVANCING MEDICINE FOR CANCER PATIENTS



Thomas Begley

Dr. Tom Begley's Research Highlighted in SUNY Chancellor's 2026 State of the University Address

The Department of Biological Sciences is proud to recognize Dr. Tom Begley as a Williams-Raycheff Endowed Professor and Associate Director of the University at Albany's RNA Institute whose research was highlighted by SUNY Chancellor John B. King Jr. during his 2026 State of the University Address.

As part of his remarks on SUNY's growing leadership in biomedical research and innovation, Chancellor King gave special attention to Dr. Begley's work on advancing medicine for cancer patients.

Dr. Begley and members of his lab are currently developing innovative approaches that help match cancer patients with newly developed therapies. By utilizing advanced software tools capable of analyzing large and complex biological datasets, the Begley laboratory can identify patients who are most likely to benefit from specific treatments.

The Chancellor also noted that this work demonstrates SUNY's commitment to leading the next generation of healthcare innovation where personalized medicine becomes increasingly effective, accessible, and impactful. Dr. Begley's research combines cutting-edge computational biology, RNA science, and translational medicine to improve patient outcomes while expanding an understanding of disease and possible future therapies.

This recognition of Dr. Begley's work during the *State of the University Address* exemplifies the research and education that is currently offered at University at Albany, the RNA Institute, and the Department of Biological Sciences. More importantly, through collaborations across disciplines and institutions, the University at Albany continues to promote discoveries that have the potential to transform healthcare and thus improve lives.

The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Dr. Begley and members of his lab on this outstanding recognition and their continued contributions to advancing scientific discoveries.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

ANDY BERGLUND AND JOHN CLEARY ENTER LEADERSHIP ROLES IN NEW RESEARCH CENTER



Andy Berglund



John Cleary

NIH Awards $6.5 Million Grant to Establish Specialized Research Center

The University at Albany and Virginia Commonwealth University (VCU) have been awarded a five-year, $6.5 million P50 grant from the National Institutes of Health (NIH) to establish a Wellstone Muscular Dystrophy Specialized Research Center (MDSRC). The award is one of only six Wellstone centers in the nation and recognizes the institutions' leadership in myotonic dystrophy research.

The center is co-directed by **Andy Berglund**, Keith Hynes Endowed Professor in STEM and director of UAlbany's RNA Institute, and Dr. Nicholas Johnson, director of VCU's Center for Inherited Muscle Research. Together, the institutions will leverage their complementary expertise to advance research on myotonic dystrophy, the most common form of adult-onset muscular dystrophy in the United States.

Supported through the NIH P50 Center program, the new Wellstone Center will integrate multidisciplinary research projects with shared scientific resources, clinical expertise, and training initiatives. The program is supported by the National Institute of Arthritis and Musculoskeletal and Skin Diseases, the Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development, the National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute, and the National Institute of Neurological Disorders and Stroke.

The center's research will focus on two major projects. The first will develop clinical outcome measures and biomarkers to prepare children with myotonic dystrophy for future clinical trials. The second will investigate the genetic factors that contribute to disease variability and influence responses to emerging therapies.

The award also establishes three core programs to support research and collaboration: an Administrative Core to strengthen partnerships with patient advocacy organizations and industry, a Resource Core to provide centralized access to cell lines, biological samples, genomic data, and phenotypic datasets, and a Training Core dedicated to preparing the next generation of muscular dystrophy researchers and clinicians.

UAlbany faculty members **John D. Cleary**, assistant director of research at the RNA Institute, and Berglund will play key leadership roles in the center alongside collaborators at VCU.

The new Wellstone Center further strengthens UAlbany's national leadership in RNA biology and translational medicine while expanding opportunities for interdisciplinary collaboration, workforce development, and the advancement of new therapeutic approaches for myotonic dystrophy and related neuromuscular diseases.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

CHERYL ANDAM'S STUDY REVEALS HOW BACTERIA SHARE DRUG RESISTANCE





Cheryl Andam

Researchers from the University at Albany and the New York State Department of Health have discovered a previously unknown way that bacteria exchange genetic information allowing them to evolve resistance to antibiotics. The findings, published in Nature Communications provide a better understanding into how the bacterium Listeria monocytogenes cause the foodborne illness listeriosis to adapt and become more difficult to treat.

Led by **Cheryl Andam**, an Associate Professor in the UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences, has found that different types of mobile genetic elements or small pieces of DNA that move within bacterial cells can exchange genetic material with one another. This process allows bacteria to acquire new combinations of genes that increase their resistance to multiple antibiotics and may also enhance their ability to cause disease.

To make this discovery, the researchers from the University at Albany and the New York State Department of Health analyzed the genomes of 936 Listeria samples collected from patients in New York State between 2000 and 2021. By mapping how different mobile genetic elements share DNA the researchers were able to identify a previously unrecognized network of genetic exchange that expands scientists' understanding of how antimicrobial resistance occurs.

These findings suggest that bacteria can evolve more quickly than previously thought by combining resistance genes from multiple sources. This new understanding could help researchers develop more effective antibiotics and improve strategies for predicting which treatments are most likely to work against specific bacterial strains. In the future, these insights may also contribute to more personalized approaches to treating bacterial infections.

The project demonstrates the importance of collaboration between UAlbany and the New York State Department of Health. By combining large-scale DNA analysis of bacteria with basic research, the two groups are working to better understand how antibiotic resistance develops and spreads. Their findings could help scientists develop new ways to treat current and future infections.

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

CHANGHWAN LEE RECEIVES $1.86M GRANT FROM NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF GENERAL MEDICAL SCIENCES





ChangHwan Lee

ChangHwan Lee received a $1.86 million grant from the National Institute of General Medical Sciences to investigate how mistakes in the way genes are turned on and off can lead to diseases such as cancer and infertility. His research will examine the cellular processes that control gene activity, with a focus on the Notch signaling pathway that is a key communication system which helps cells develop and function correctly. The findings could improve scientists' understanding of how stem cells develop and provide new understandings into diseases that occur when genes are not properly controlled.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

HANNAH SHORROCK AND JOHN CLEARY PURSUE SINGLE TREATMENT FOR MULTIPLE NEUROLOGICAL DISEASES

Biology Researchers Developing Single Compound for Treating Multiple Diseases

Two University at Albany researchers are taking a different approach by developing a single compound that could potentially treat dozens of rare neurological diseases in many patients worldwide. Their work has recently been supported by a $50,000 award from the SUNY Technology Accelerator Fund which will help move the research closer to future clinical trials.



John Cleary



Hannah Shorrock

The research is led by Assistant Professor **Hannah Shorrock** of the Department of Biological Sciences and **John Cleary**, Assistant Director of Research at the RNA Institute, whose work has identified common genetic links shared by many neurological diseases. One well-known example is Huntington's disease, which is caused by an abnormal repetition of a short DNA sequence known as CAG. This repeated CAG sequence leads to the production of harmful proteins that gradually damage brain cells. Over time, people affected by these neurological diseases such as Huntington's may lose the ability to walk, speak, or perform everyday tasks, and in later stages have difficulty swallowing or breathing.

Rather than treating each neurological disease separately, the UAlbany researchers are working to reduce the harmful effects caused by excessive CAG repeats in the body by developing one compound that could be used to treat many neurological diseases that have dysfunctional CAG repeat. To date, Drs. Shorrock and Cleary have developed a compound that helps reduce the damage caused by these abnormal DNA repeats. However, the compound does not dissolve well in liquids that are safe for long-term patient use. Because some laboratory solvents can cause side effects, the team has created 40 new versions of the compound in hopes of identifying one that is both safe and effective.

Funding from the SUNY Technology Accelerator Fund will allow the team to test these new versions of the compound and identify the most promising treatment. If successful, this step would move the research closer to clinical trials of which is a major milestone before any treatment could be approved for patients suffering from CAG-related neurological diseases. Past support for Drs. Shorrock and Cleary's research includes the National Ataxia Foundation, the National Institutes of Health, New York State, and State University of New York.

Together, this research highlights how UAlbany scientists from the Department of Biological Sciences and the RNA Institute are advancing innovative solutions with the potential to improve the lives of people affected with neurological diseases.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

MARLENE BELFORT MODERATES UALBANY-HOSTED CONVERSATION ON WOMEN IN SCIENCE



Marlene Belfort



Nancy Hopkins



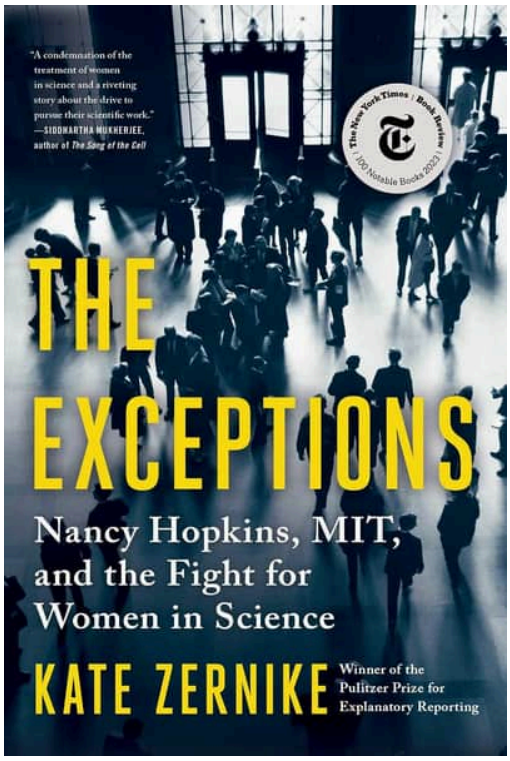
Kate Zernike

Author Kate Zernike and Biologist Nancy Hopkins discuss Gender Equity in Science

The University at Albany recently welcomed molecular biologist Dr. **Nancy Hopkins** and Pulitzer Prize-winning journalist and author **Kate Zernike** for a conversation on gender equity in science, leadership, and academic reform. This virtual event was presented through a collaboration between the New York State Writers Institute, the RNA Institute, and Women in Science and Health (WISH).

Moderated by Distinguished Professor Dr. **Marlene Belfort**, the discussion focused on Zernike's 2023 book, 'The Exceptions: Nancy Hopkins, MIT, and the Fight for Women in Science' which described the efforts of a group of women scientists at MIT who challenged systemic gender discrimination in academia.

Paul Grondahl, Director of the New York State Writers Institute introduced the speakers and emphasized Hopkins' groundbreaking scientific contributions including her novel work on establishing zebrafish as a model organism for studying vertebrate development and cancer. He also recognized her decades-long support for women in science including her leadership of the landmark 1999 MIT report on gender bias that provided national recognition about equity in academia.



During the discussion, Zernike explained the meaning behind the title 'The Exceptions' noting that many women scientists believed they had to be "exceptional" simply to survive and succeed in scientific disciplines traditionally dominated by men. Hopkins reflected on the personal and professional struggles that led her and her colleagues to organize and report on the disparities affecting women faculty at MIT.
Hopkins emphasized that the movement succeeded because it became a collective effort in the beginning among sixteen women faculty.

She described the one moment when fellow scientist Dr. Mary Lou Pardue agreed that the inequities Hopkins' made public helped bring together a group of faculty members who worked together to change the much-needed MIT policies.

The discussion stressed the important role that male colleagues played in supporting a non-discriminatory workplace for women in science and academia.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY SPOTLIGHT

ANNALISA SCIMEMI RECEIVES INAUGURAL AWARD FROM NEW SUNY BRAIN INSTITUTE



Annalisa Scimemi

SUNY Brain Institute Promises New Levels of Scientific Collaboration across SUNY Campuses

The University at Albany, College of Arts and Sciences and the Department of Biological Sciences will play a central role in a major new statewide investment in neuroscience research. Governor Kathy Hochul announced this past October a $10 million appropriation in the 2025–26 state budget to establish the new SUNY Brain Institute. The SUNY Brain Institute is a multi-campus initiative designed to expand SUNY's research and academic programs in areas of neuroscience. This new investment will fund shared equipment, research infrastructure, and collaborative projects across SUNY campuses including UAlbany and the three fellow University Centers as well as Upstate Medical University, Downstate Health Sciences University, and other research institutions.

Governor Hochul pointed out that the SUNY Brain Institute will utilize the breadth and expertise of SUNY's more than 600 active neuroscience researchers to gain a better understanding of neurological diseases such as Alzheimer's, Parkinson's, stroke, and other cognitive disorders. The institute will also work to develop new treatments to prevent, slow, or manage these conditions. State University of New York Chancellor John B. King Jr. and the SUNY Board of Trustees praised the initiative as a major step forward that will advance research on mental health, neurodegenerative diseases, and cutting-edge technologies and therapeutics.



Dr. **Annalisa Scimemi**, an Associate Professor in the Department of Biological Sciences received one of the inaugural Brain Institute Awards. Dr. Scimemi's award is to investigate the earliest biological changes associated with Alzheimer's disease, as well as the impact of circadian rhythms on learning and memory. Scimemi's team, an international and interdisciplinary group of scientists spanning biology, engineering, computer science, and neuroscience, studies how different brain cells communicate and how disruptions in those signals may lead to cognitive decline. Different types of brain cells have distinct roles and having a better understanding of the chemical signals they use to communicate is essential. Her team works to detect early signs of disease by studying how the brain's electrical activity changes before memory or thinking issues appear.

Dr. Scimemi's lab studies how bred mice with Alzheimer's-like changes behave differently from healthy mice. By looking at subtle patterns of brain activity, Scimemi's team hopes to develop noninvasive ways to detect the disease early. Early detection is critical as more than 7 million Americans currently live with Alzheimer's and that number is expected to rise sharply in the coming decades.

The lab is also investigating how circadian rhythms might influence brain function and behavior. By focusing on the hippocampus, a region critical for learning and memory, Scimemi's team has found that the brain's ability to learn new information changes at different times of the day. They are studying how these natural daily rhythms affect learning and whether disruptions in the body's internal clock may contribute to diseases like Alzheimer's. Understanding this potential link could help researchers figure out whether changes in circadian rhythms cause brain degeneration or are a result of it.

UAlbany is set to become a hub on advancing discoveries, training the next generation of neuroscientists, and contributing to the health and well-being of communities across New York State and beyond.

UAlbany, the College of Arts and Sciences, and the Department of Biological Sciences congratulate Dr. Scimemi and her team on their remarkable accomplishments and the significant impact they are making on neuroscience research and scientific discovery.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

RESEARCHER SPOTLIGHT

ANDAM LAB RESEARCHER HELOISE MULLER'S STUDY FEATURED IN *NATURE COMMUNICATIONS*



Heloise Muller



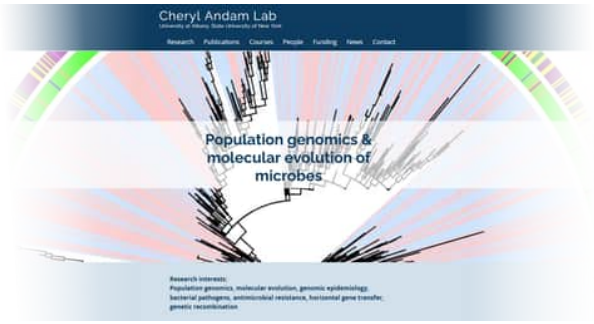
Cheryl Andam

Andam Lab Researcher's Work on Bacterial Genome Evolution Gains National Exposure

The University at Albany Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Dr. **Héloïse Muller** who recently completed her postdoctoral fellowship in the laboratory of Associate Professor **Cheryl Andam**. During her time in the Andam Lab, Dr. Muller conducted research in evolutionary genomics that focused on the mechanisms of horizontal gene transfer and the roles of mobile genetic elements in bacterial evolution.

Her work at UAlbany concluded in a first-author publication in the November 2025 issue of Nature Communications titled "Genetic exchange networks bridge mobile DNA vehicles in the bacterial pathogen Listeria monocytogenes. This study reveals how genetic exchange among mobile DNA elements such as plasmids, transposons, and phages help drive the evolution of Listeria monocytogenes.

This publication represents a collaborative effort by members of the Andam Lab which includes Dr. **Odion O. Ikhimiukor** (postdoctoral researcher), Dr. **Maitiú Marmion** (postdoctoral researcher), **Manuela Montoya-Giraldo** (Ph.D. student), and **Kathryn R. Piper** (Ph.D. student) together with scientists from the Wadsworth Center, New York State Department of Health who contributed data, analyses, and discussions to this study.



Andam Lab: https://andamlab.wixsite.com/home

Dr. Muller has now begun a new postdoctoral position at the Institut de Biologie de l'École Normale Supérieure (IBENS) in Paris, France where she is investigating how structural variations influence adaptation to new environments in Caenorhabditis elegans. Her recent postdoctoral appointment at UAlbany builds on a strong and very successful record of academic and research training that includes a Ph.D. from Université Paris-Saclay and prior research experiences at the École Normale Supérieure de Lyon, the Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, and the Swedish Museum of Natural History.

The Department of Biological Sciences recognizes Drs. Héloïse Muller and Cheryl Andam along with members of the Andam lab for this outstanding accomplishment and their contribution to advancing the understanding of bacterial evolution and genomic adaptation.

Dr. Muller's Nature Communications article ("Genetic Exchange Networks Bridge Mobile DNA Vehicles in the Bacterial Pathogen Listeria Monocytogenes") can be found at https://www.nature.com/articles/s41467-025-64743-x

Information on the Andam Lab can be found at https://andamlab.wixsite/home

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

RESEARCHER SPOTLIGHT

GABY FUCHS AND KAALAK REDDY RECEIVE GRANT TO STUDY "INOSINE TRIPHOSPHATASE (ITPASE) DEFICIENCY" DISEASE



Kaalak Reddy, Mark Handley, Jacob Schroader, Naa Adade and Gabriele Fuchs

RNA Institute Researchers Receive NIH Funding to Investigate Fatal Genetic Disorder

Co-investigators **Kaalak Reddy** and **Gabriele Fuchs** were awarded $420,000 from the Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development to study the molecular mechanisms that drive a rare but fatal genetic disorder that affects the heart and brain known as ITPase enzyme deficiency.

Co-investigators Kaalak Reddy and Gabriele Fuchs were awarded $420,000 from the Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development to study the molecular mechanisms that drive a rare but fatal genetic disorder that affects the heart and brain known as ITPase enzyme deficiency.

The disease is caused by a missing enzyme (ITPase) that is responsible for cleaning up unconventional nucleotides in cells: Without it, the coding instructions carried in RNA get disrupted, causing fatal problems in heart and brain cells.

"Not much is known about the broader cellular consequences of this inosine misincorporation into RNA," said Fuchs. "Our previous work shows that inosine misincorporation disrupts the process of making proteins and their function, which is a central question that my lab will address in this work."

"RNA molecules are made up of building blocks called nucleotides which typically include adenine (A), guanine (G), cytosine (C) and uracil (U)," said Kaalak Reddy, research faculty at UAlbany's RNA Institute who has been studying this disorder since 2014. "These building blocks provide the code to maintain RNA functions which includes generating proteins that keep cells functioning properly.



"We are trying to determine why the accumulation and misincorporation of inosine into RNA leads to a fatal disease," said Reddy. "This understanding could give us new insights into the cellular mechanism underlying this and other related diseases."

https://www.albany.edu/news-center/news/2025-rna-institute-researchers-receive-nih-funding-investigate-fatal-genetic

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY HONORS

THOMAS BEGLEY NAMED WILLIAMS-RAYCHEFF ENDOWED PROFESSOR IN BIOLOGY



Thomas Begley

Professor, Researcher, and Alumnus Thomas Begley's Accomplishments Recognized by University

The Department of Biological Sciences recognizes Dr. **Thomas Begley**, a Professor of Biological Sciences and Associate Director of The RNA Institute, on being named the Williams-Raycheff Endowed Professor in Biology. Established through a generous gift from Margaret Raycheff-Williams '44 and Roy O. Williams, this endowed professorship recognizes faculty whose scholarship, teaching, and service demonstrate excellence in the life sciences.

Dr. Begley completed his B.S. in Biology at UAlbany in 1994 and went on to earn his Ph.D. in 1999 under the mentorship of Professor **Richard Cunningham** where he studied how organisms respond to various types of "stress" at the cellular level. After completing a post-doctoral position, he returned to UAlbany as a faculty member in 2004. Since then, the Begley laboratory has made several major discoveries including showing that RNA can be reprogrammed to enhance cellular survival under stress. His group also developed computational methods to analyze RNA molecules within cells, identifying potential therapeutic targets relevant to cancer and degenerative diseases, and the identification of a new tumor suppressor gene in colorectal cancer. Together, these discoveries demonstrate how basic research can lead to new approaches to disease detection, prevention, and treatment.

In addition to his research achievements, Dr. Begley has made significant contributions to education and training at UAlbany. As director of the RNA Institute's Training Program in RNA Science and Technology, he has provided students with valuable experience in both molecular and computational biology. His mentorship has helped prepare numerous undergraduates and graduate students for careers in biomedical research, biotechnology, and medicine.

Dr. Begley's accomplishments have been recognized across the State University of New York system and beyond. In 2023, he was promoted to Distinguished Professor, the highest academic rank conferred by the SUNY Board of Trustees. His selection as the Williams-Raycheff Endowed Professor in Biology further acknowledges his continued excellence in scholarship, teaching, and service.

Once again, congratulations to Dr. Begley and thank you for your continued support from the University, CAS, Department of Biological Sciences and The RNA Institute.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY HONORS

MARLENE BELFORT RECEIVES AWIS ZENITH AWARD



Marlene Belfort

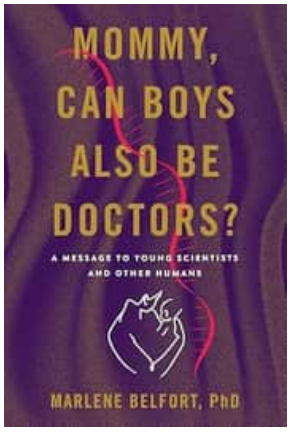
Dr. Belfort Receives AWIS Zenith Award for Scientific Leadership and Inclusion

Dr. **Marlene Belfort**, Distinguished Professor of Biological and Biomedical Sciences and Senior Advisor of the RNA Institute, has received the Association for Women in Science (AWIS) Zenith Award. The honor recognizes her lifetime of scientific achievement and her longstanding commitment to advancing diversity, equity, and inclusion in STEM.

The AWIS Zenith Award is presented to senior scientists who demonstrate exceptional leadership, innovation, and sustained efforts to broaden participation in science.

Dr. Belfort's career covers more than four decades of research in microbial genetics and biochemistry. She is a member of both the National Academy of Sciences and the American Academy of Arts and Sciences.

At UAlbany, she has been a leader in developing programs that support and mentor emerging scientists. She co-founded Women in Science and Health (WISH), contributed to NSF ADVANCE Project SAGES, and founded the Graduate Pathway for Scholars (GPS) program to support the recruitment and advancement of underrepresented students. She also serves in the leadership of the HHMI-funded Success in Science program which supports student retention in STEM.



In 2025, Dr. Belfort published Mommy Can Boys Also be Doctors? A Message to Young Scientists and Other Humans, which reflects on her experiences and emphasizes resilience, mentorship, and building inclusive scientific communities. The award highlights both her scientific accomplishments and her enduring impact on fostering a more inclusive STEM environment.



Andrew Berglund

The RNA Institute Celebrated at LifeSciencesNY Together ’25 for Distinguished Achievement in Research

Members of the RNA Institute gathered at the LifeSciencesNY Together ’25 meeting held at the Marriott Syracuse Downtown from November 12–13, 2025 where leaders from the biomedical and life sciences came together for presentations, networking, and awards recognizing excellence in research, innovation, education, and economic development.

At this year’s event, The RNA Institute received the 2025 Distinguished Achievement in Research Award for its leadership in RNA biology, therapeutic discovery, advanced technologies, and workforce development. Director Dr. **Andrew (Andy) Berglund**, Distinguished Professor of Biological Sciences delivered the acceptance speech on behalf of the Institute emphasizing the team’s cutting-edge work in RNA science and noting how the award recognizes the contributions of The RNA Institute’s scientists, staff, trainees, students, and collaborators in advancing biomedical and life sciences research, education, and technology.

Additional LifeSciencesNY Together ’25 Honorees:

- Immunaeon – Industry Pioneer
- Upstate Biotech Ventures – Project of the Year
- Clarkson University – Distinguished Achievement in Life Sciences Education
- Fisher Scientific – Ecosystem Partner
- Marnie LaVigne, Launch NY – Economic Development Superstar
- Syed Ahmed Mustafa, BioSpherix – Groundbreaker
- Canyon Labs – Bio/Med Catalyst
- Kodak Pharmaceuticals – Newcomer of the Year

This two-day event featured panel discussions on new ideas in product development, how organizations can access statewide resources, and ways to navigate today’s changing healthcare system. The event opened on November 12 with a members’ dinner and awards ceremony followed by a featured presentation from Sarah Matt, MD, MBA, author of The Borderless Healthcare Revolution. The program continued Thursday, November 13 with a keynote address by Ankur Kalra, MD founder of MakeADent.org and host of the award-winning cardiology podcast Parallax.

The University at Albany, College of Arts and Sciences and the Department of Biological Sciences congratulate Dr. Berglund and entire RNA Institute team on this well-deserved honor and celebrate their continued success in advancing research excellence, innovation, and education.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY HONORS

CHRISTINE GERVASI RECOGNIZED FOR UALBANY *EMBER AWARD*

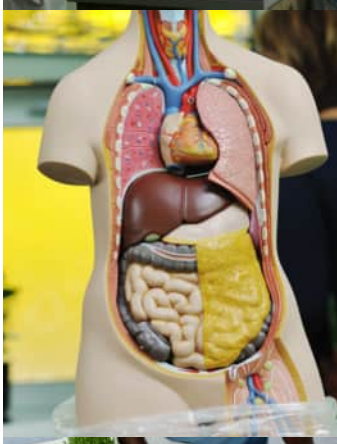


Christine Gervasi

Dr. Christine Gervasi's Work with Undergraduates Recognized as Distinguished Nominee for Ember Award

The Department of Biological Sciences is proud to announce Dr. **Christine Gervasi**'s selection as a Distinguished Nominee for the Ember Award. The Ember Award recognizes those individuals who promote engagement, build community, and ensure that students feel supported throughout their time at UAlbany.







As a Distinguished Nominee, Christine was recognized for her outstanding commitment to undergraduate students and her contributions to the UAlbany community at the Annual Academic Innovator Awards ceremony.

Christine's nomination reflects nearly two decades of dedicated service as an instructor and mentor for first-year students in the biological sciences. As coordinator of the ABIO 201/202Z General Biology laboratory courses, she has guided hundreds of students each semester through a critical transition period in their academic careers. Her efforts help students develop essential scientific skills while building the confidence needed to succeed in their studies

In the classroom Christine promotes a learning environment where students feel welcomed, supported, and encouraged to actively engage with course material. She promotes curiosity and collaboration, encouraging both students and teaching assistants to ask questions and work together to better understand key concepts. She also seeks feedback and revises her curriculum to maintain a high standard of excellence.

In addition to her teaching and departmental service, Christine has also been an active member of UAlbany's Pre-Health Committee. As a member of this University-wide committee, she supports students pursuing careers in healthcare by reviewing applications, conducting interviews, and providing input for letters of recommendation. Christine's involvement with the Pre-Health Committee plays an important role in supporting each student's goal of having a career in the medical field.

Beyond the classroom Christine works closely with faculty, staff, and teaching assistants to support the mission and goals of the University, the College of Arts and Sciences, and the Department of Biological Sciences through her role as Chair of the Department's Recruitment Committee. As Chair of this very important committee, Christine volunteers countless hours preparing materials and coordinating participation for key outreach and engagement events such as the UAlbany's "Open House" and the annual "Munch with the Majors."

This work reflects her broader dedication to furthering engagement both on campus and in the surrounding community. At this time, the Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Christine on being recognized through her excellence in instruction, mentorship, and service as a Distinguished Nominee for the Ember Award — a job well-done!

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY HONORS

UALBANY FACULTY RANKED AMONG THE WORLD'S BEST SCIENTISTS IN THEIR DISCIPLINES

STANFORD
Citation Impact Report

Stanford Citation Impact Report shows UAlbany Biology Faculty Among World's Top Scientists in their Disciplines

As recently featured in *UAlbany's Dozens of UAlbany Researchers Among World's Top 2% of Scientists* (https://www.albany.edu/news-center/news/2025-dozens-ualbany-researchers-among-worlds-top-2-scientists), the Department of Biological Sciences is proud to recognize three of its faculty members being among the world's top 2% scientists according to the 2025 Stanford University Global Citation Impact Database published through Elsevier and they include Dr. **Annalisa Scimemi**, Dr. **Alex Valm**, and Dr. **Ing-Nang Wang**. These three scientists join more than 50 UAlbany researchers listed in this year's Stanford ranking.

The *Stanford University Citation Impact Report* evaluates the work of more than six million researchers worldwide and identifies top performers using standardized citation metrics, publication records, and field impact data. This recognition emphasizes UAlbany's national and international presence as a Carnegie R1 Research Institution and reflects the outstanding scientific contributions of its faculty.

The University at Albany, College of Arts and Sciences and Department of Biological Sciences congratulates the three faculty members included in this year's Stanford University Report and acknowledges their outstanding achievements in research.



Annalisa Scimemi

Annalisa Scimemi

Dr. **Annalisa Scimemi**, Associate Professor of Biology and Adjunct Professor of the Department of Physics, is an internationally recognized neuroscientist whose research examines how neurons and astrocytes communicate to regulate synaptic functions. Her work focuses on the regulation of glutamate transporters such as EAAT2/GLT-1 and cellular mechanisms involved in neurodevelopmental and neurodegenerative disorders such as Alzheimer's disease.

Dr. Scimemi earned her MSc in Biology from the University of Pisa and her PhD in Biophysics from SISSA/ISAS in Italy. She later completed research fellowships at University College London and the National Institutes of Health. Since joining the UAlbany faculty in 2015, she has authored 14 commentaries, 3 book chapters and 27 original research articles with several published in *The Journal of Neuroscience, European Journal of Neuroscience,* and *Cell Reports*. Her work has been cited more than 2,600 times.

Dr. Scimemi's research program is supported by NIH and NSF awards totaling nearly $2.85 million. She also serves as President of the Hudson-Berkshire Chapter of the Society for Neuroscience, holds editorial and review positions with several journals, and has mentored and advised numerous student researchers at UAlbany.

During the academic year, Dr. Scimemi currently instructs ABIO 515B Responsible Conduct and Skills in Scientific Communication and ABIO 341 Neurobiology. She also contributes to community and professional services and various training opportunities for students at the undergraduate, graduate and high school levels.

FACULTY HONORS

UALBANY FACULTY RANKED AMONG THE WORLD'S BEST SCIENTISTS IN THEIR DISCIPLINES (CONT'D)



Alex Valm

Alex Valm

Dr. **Alex Valm** is an Associate Professor of Biology, Coordinator of A.I. in Biology and an Associate Faculty Member of the RNA Institute. His research focuses on a better understanding of microbial biology using high-resolution imaging, computational approaches, and new A.I. technologies to study microbiome structure and behavior.

Dr. Valm received his PhD in Pathobiology from Brown University, his MS in Cell Biology from UNC Chapel Hill, and his BS in Biology with Honors from Bradley University. He completed a NIH PRAT Postdoctoral Fellowship at the National Institute of Child Health and Human Development under Dr. Jennifer Lippincott-Schwartz where he specialized in high-resolution microscopy.

Since joining UAlbany in 2017, Dr. Valm has authored 21 peer-reviewed publications notably *Immunity, Bioinformatics,* and *Journal of Dental Research*. His research is currently supported by NIH R01 grants of $4 million. He has been recognized with the 2023 UAlbany Excellence in Research Award and the 2021 RNA Institute Excellence in Research Award.

Dr. Valm teaches ABIO 397 Microbiome in Health as well as advanced undergraduate and graduate research courses. He also contributes to conference leadership, public outreach, and training programs for high school, undergraduate, and graduate students.



Ing-Nang Wang

Ing-Nang Wang

Dr. **Ing-Nang Wang**, Associate Professor of Biology studies bacteriophage biology, microbial evolution as well as the ecological and genetic factors that shape these relationships. His work has contributed to understanding phage life history traits, host evolution, and microbial population dynamics with applications relevant to infectious disease ecology.

Dr. Wang earned his PhD in Biological Sciences from Stony Brook University, his MS from the University of Nebraska–Lincoln, and a BS from National Taiwan University. He joined UAlbany as an Assistant Professor in 2002 and has served as Associate Professor since 2008.

He has authored 40 peer-reviewed publications spanning virology, evolutionary biology, microbial ecology, and wildlife disease with recent articles in *Frontiers in Microbiology* and *iScience*. His research has been supported by several NIH grants, which includes an R21 award for engineering bacteriophage host range as well as a notable grant from Academia Sinica to study molecular parasites. In 2023, he received a University at Albany research award to support new phage purification studies.

Dr. Wang teaches ABIO 329 Genetics of Human Disease, and ABIO429/529 Molecular Virology. He also contributes extensively to scientific peer review as an evaluator for the NIH, NSF, and numerous journals and serves on several departmental and university committees.

The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Dr. Scimemi, Dr. Valm, and Dr. Wang for earning distinction among the world's top 2 percent of scientists. Their accomplishments reveal the department's strengths across neuroscience, microbiology, and evolutionary biology, and demonstrate UAlbany's impact on research and scientific discovery.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY HONORS

RYAN THURMAN RECEIVES 2025 DEAN'S AWARD



Ryan Thurman



Dr. Thurman and Chair Larsen at Award Ceremony

Dr. Thurman Receives Award for Teaching Excellence

The Department of Biological Sciences is proud to announce that Dr. **Ryan Thurman** has been selected as the recipient of the University at Albany, College of Arts and Sciences 2025 Dean's Award for Outstanding Achievement in Teaching Excellence.

This award recognizes faculty who go above and beyond in supporting student learning and success.

Nominees must have taught full-time at the University at Albany for at least three years and consistently shown excellence in teaching and mentoring.

The award considers many aspects of a teacher's work, including engaging classroom instruction, creative approaches to teaching, strong advising, and meaningful guidance of student projects and research

For the past seven years as a Lecturer in Biological Sciences, Dr. Thurman has distinguished himself as an educator and a mentor whose work has significantly advanced forensic science education at UAlbany.

Dr. Thurman holds both a B.S. and Ph.D. in Chemistry from the University of Central Arkansas. His early career included serving as a Forensic Chemist at the Arkansas State Crime Laboratory where he gained hands-on experience with analytical techniques central to Forensic Science investigation. In 2013, he earned a Lineberger Comprehensive Cancer Center Fellowship at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. At UNC, he conducted advanced research on the KRAS signaling protein and its interactions with small-molecule inhibitors using multi-dimensional NMR spectroscopy.

Since joining UAlbany in 2018, Dr. Thurman has played a key role in expanding and strengthening the University's Forensic Science curriculum. For example, he redesigned ABIO 175: Forensic Science and Investigation, a non-major course whose enrollment has increased from approximately 70 students to more than 500 per semester. He also instructs additional undergraduate and graduate courses including Forensic Science, Forensic Chemistry and Toxicology, and Instrumental and Biochemical Analysis.

Dr. Thurman has also been an active mentor in undergraduate and graduate research. To date, he has supervised for credit eight undergraduate researchers and thirteen master's students in areas such as water and soil analysis, forensic entomology, toxic mushroom identification, and decomposition chemistry.

Dr Thurman has been involved in STEM outreach that has provided attendees with hands-on experience by instructing a University in High School summer course for secondary educators offering ABIO 175 for UAlbany credit, contributing to Girls Inc.® Eureka! "Journey to Forensic Science Discovery" Summer Camp and participating in a weeklong forensic science program for area students through the 2025 Provost Community Outreach Initiative.

Since 2023, Dr. Thurman has served as Director of the Minor in Forensic Science and the M.S. in Forensic Science Investigation and Management programs. Both programs have seen increased enrollment, expanded internship placements, and new career opportunities through partnerships with state and federal forensic science agencies. He is also collaborating with colleagues across the College of Arts and Sciences to co-develop a new Department of Biological Sciences B.S. in Forensic Science program.

A Well-Deserved Honor

Throughout his tenure at UAlbany, Dr. Thurman has demonstrated the highest standards of teaching, mentorship, leadership, and service. His contributions have already left a profound impact on UAlbany students, and his vision continues to shape the future of forensic science education both locally and nationally.

The Department of Biological Sciences congratulates Dr. Ryan Thurman on receiving the 2025 Dean's Award for Outstanding Achievement in Teaching Excellence.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY HONORS

ANDREW BERGLUND NAMED UALBANY 2025 ACADEMIC LAUREATE



Andy Berglund

Distinguished Professor Berglund Honored by University



The Department of Biological Sciences proudly congratulates **Dr. Andrew Berglund,** Distinguished Professor of Biological Sciences and Director of the University at Albany's RNA Institute for being named the 2025 Academic Laureate by the University at Albany Foundation.

This honor was presented at the 44th Annual Citizen Laureate Awards Dinner of which was held on October 31, 2025, at the University's Broadview Center.

For more than four decades, the Citizen Laureate Awards have celebrated individuals whose leadership and service in academia, business, and public life.

The 2025 award recipients include **Dr. Berglund** (Academic Laureate) along with **Thomas Tyrrell** and **Marcia J. White** (Community Laureates). Together, they reflect the University at Albany Foundation's mission to recognize those whose work strengthens the relationship between higher education and the community.

A distinguished molecular biologist and leader in RNA science, Dr. Berglund has made major contributions to a better understanding of RNA and developing therapeutic strategies for neurodegenerative and neuromuscular disorders that includes Parkinson's disease, Alzheimer's disease, and myotonic dystrophy. His many honors include the President's Excellence Award in Research and Creative Activities and the UAlbany Alumni Association's Collins Citizen Award.

Dr. Berglund is also deeply committed to education and mentorship. As a faculty member in UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences, he has inspired and guided students at the high school, undergraduate, and graduate levels that prepare the next generation of RNA scientists.

His leadership at the RNA Institute continues to expand opportunities for collaborative discovery and training in cutting-edge RNA science.

The Department of Biological Sciences extends its congratulations to Dr. Berglund on this well-deserved recognition and thanks him for his continued contributions to advancing science and education as well as his continued support to the University at Albany and the broader community.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

FACULTY RETIREMENT

RICHARD CUNNINGHAM



Richard Cunningham

Celebrating Dr. Richard Cunningham's 40+ Years at UAlbany

After more than four decades of research, teaching, leadership, mentorship, and service, Dr. **Richard "Rick" Cunningham** is retiring from the University at Albany's Department of Biological Sciences. A scientist, educator, mentor, colleague, and Chair of the Department of Biological Sciences from 2014 to 2024, Rick leaves behind a legacy in molecular genetics and DNA repair research as well as in the generations of students, fellows, and peers he mentored throughout his tenure at UAlbany.

Rick earned his A.B. and Sc.B. degrees in Biology from Brown University in 1971 and received his Ph.D. in Biology from The Johns Hopkins University in 1977. Following postdoctoral training at Yale University School of Medicine and The Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine, he joined UAlbany in 1982 as an Assistant Professor. He was promoted to Associate Professor in 1988 and Professor in 1993. In addition to his faculty appointments, Rick served as Associate Director of the Center for Functional Genomics (2002-2009) and the GeNYSis Center for Excellence in Cancer Genomics (2004-2009).

Since 1982, Rick's research program at UAlbany focused on understanding how cells identify and repair damaged DNA which provided insights into various mechanisms that are used to protect organisms from mutation, disease, and cancer. Throughout his career he published an impressive 93 scientific papers in leading scientific journals including Nature, Science, Genomics, Current Biology, Journal of Biochemistry, Journal of Molecular Biology,Cell, and Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences while receiving continuous support from the National Institutes of Health and the National Science Foundation.

In addition to his scientific accomplishments, Rick has been a mentor and advisor to undergraduate and graduate students as well as postdoctoral fellows who went on to successful careers in academia, medicine, biotechnology and industry. He also taught undergraduate and graduate coursework in Bacteriology, Molecular Genetics, Microbiology, Biochemistry, Graduate Seminar in MCDN, and Molecular Structure and Biochemistry.

Rick also made significant service contributions to the Biology Department, College of Arts and Sciences, and UAlbany. He chaired numerous committees including the Graduate Programs Committee, Institutional Biosafety Committee, University Committee on Recombinant DNA, and University Radiation Safety Committee. He also served on national grant review panels for the National Science Foundation and National Institutes of Health and on the editorial boards of leading journals in molecular biology, genetics, biochemistry, and DNA repair.

We wish Rick all the best in retirement and thank him for his many years of contributions to research, teaching, service, and leadership in the Department of Biological Sciences, the College of Arts and Sciences, and the University at Albany. We are also grateful for the guidance and support he has provided to countless students and colleagues throughout his career.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY BIOLOGY ALUMNI STORIES



Holly Ahern
Class of 1994

Holly Ahern: Advancing Lyme Disease Diagnostics Through Science and Innovation

Holly Ahern has built a distinguished career in science, education, and biotechnology since earning her B.S. in Biology/Medical Technology Degree from UAlbany in 1980 and her M.S. in Molecular Biology in 1994. As an undergraduate, she participated in a joint UAlbany–Albany Medical Center Medical Technology program that provided hands-on experience in clinical laboratory technologies and helped launch her career in the life sciences. Today, Ahern serves as Co-Founder and Chief Scientific Officer (CSO) of Aces Diagnostics, a biotechnology company working to develop improved diagnostic tools for detecting Lyme disease. As Chief Scientific Officer of Aces Diagnostics, her recent work has helped advance new methods for detecting Lyme disease by using biomarker research and artificial intelligence to identify infections earlier and more accurately. She is also a Professor Emerita of Microbiology at SUNY Adirondack where she continues to teach part-time and mentor students. Reflecting on her time at UAlbany, Ahern credits the Department of Biological Sciences with providing the scientific training, research experience, and critical thinking skills that have supported her success as an educator, researcher, and entrepreneur. She encourages students to follow their curiosity, trust their instincts, and embrace the many opportunities that a degree in Biological Sciences can provide.



Wade Blanchard
Class of 1989

Wade Blanchard: Inspiring Generations Through Science Education

Wade Blanchard earned his B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 1987 and later completed an M.S. in Science Education in 1989. Although he initially considered careers in medicine and ecology, his passion for teaching ultimately led him to a 35-year career as a high school biology and chemistry instructor. Blanchard credits many of his accomplishments to the advisement and support he received from UAlbany faculty and staff including Meg Stewart, Jerram Brown, Helen Ghiradella, Alice Jacklet, and especially Dan McKinley whose guidance, encouragement, and commitment had a lasting impact on both his academic and professional goals. As an undergraduate, Blanchard conducted independent research in agroecology in northern Nigeria. Reflecting on his time at UAlbany, he emphasizes the importance of building relationships with faculty and staff and encourages current students to take advantage of research opportunities, office hours, and personal connections that can shape both their education and future careers. Now retired, he continues to share his love of science by teaching chemistry laboratories at SUNY Cobleskill while enjoying time with his family, gardening, and community activities.



Jeffrey Bransky
Class of 2022

Jeffrey Bransky: Pursuing Excellence in Medicine

Jeffrey Bransky earned dual B.S. Degrees in Biology and Communications from UAlbany in 2022. With a lifelong fascination for the natural world and a goal of becoming a medical doctor, Bransky found the Department of Biological Sciences rigorous coursework and supportive faculty instrumental in preparing him for a career in healthcare. One of his favorite memories was collaborating with classmates on a semester-long virology project, an experience that promoted teamwork and scientific inquiry. Following graduation, Bransky attended medical school and recently matched into an Obstetrics and Gynecology residency at Atrium Health Navicent Hospital in Macon, Georgia where he now trains as a resident physician. Reflecting on his time at UAlbany, he credits the UAlbany with strengthening his critical-thinking skills, work ethic, and time-management while encouraging him to engage with professors and mentors who played an important role in his success. He encourages current students to stay focused on their long-term goals and take advantage of the many opportunities and resources available to them both inside and outside the classroom.



Steven Buteau

Steven Buteau: From Science Teacher to Air Force Pilot and Leader

Steven Buteau came to UAlbany with plans to become a physician earning a B.S. in Biology and a Teaching Certificate. Although he initially planned to pursue a career in medicine, Buteau's experiences at UAlbany helped him discover a passion for teaching and develop the confidence and independence that influenced his future. After teaching middle school science, Buteau went on to serve for 30 years as an officer and pilot in the United States Air Force. Now largely retired from the Air Force, he remains active in education by tutoring students and teaching at a local community college. Looking back on his experiences, Buteau credits UAlbany with helping him build the confidence, knowledge, and leadership skills that supported his careers in education and the military. He encourages current and future UAlbany students to develop independence while also recognizing the importance of working with mentors, professors, and their peers.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY BIOLOGY ALUMNI STORIES



Justin Camacho
Class of 2020

Justin Camacho: From UAlbany Researcher to Harvard Physician-in-Training

Justin Camacho earned his B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 2020 and is completing his lifelong goal of becoming a physician. Camacho credits the Department of Biological Sciences with providing him with the academic foundation, mentorship, and research experiences that helped prepare him for medical school. As an undergraduate, he conducted genetics research in the Rangan Laboratory where he developed technical and scientific skills that continue to support his medical career. After graduating from UAlbany, Camacho excelled in medical school, graduating at the top of his class in 2025, and is now a resident physician training at Harvard. Reflecting on his undergraduate years, Camacho emphasizes the value of collaboration, strong relationships, leadership, and persistence. He encourages current students to stay focused on their goals, embrace challenges as opportunities for growth, and make the most of the experiences available to them. Outside of academics, he enjoys traveling and exploring new places of which he believes helps him grow both personally and professionally.



Armend Cobovic
Class of 2014

Armend Cobovic: Advancing Healthcare Through Artificial Intelligence

After earning his B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 2015, Armend Cobovic combined his interest in science and technology into a career helping improve healthcare. Today, he serves as a Senior Product Manager for Artificial Intelligence at Truveta where he helps develop AI tools that enable researchers and healthcare organizations to learn from one of the nation's largest collections of patient data. Before joining Truveta, Cobovic worked on several innovative healthcare technologies which included AI medical tools and data-driven research at organizations such as Butterfly Network, Mayo Clinic Platform, and Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center. Looking back on his time at UAlbany, Cobovic credits faculty mentorship and hands-on research opportunities with helping him develop the curiosity, critical-thinking skills, and collaborative approaches that continue to shape his work in science, technology, and healthcare.



Michael Feller
Class of 1981

Michael Feller: Following a Passion for Nature and Conservation

Michael Feller's journey through UAlbany clearly demonstrates the value of interdisciplinary learning and following one's passions. Originally a Biology major, Feller combined his interests in botany, archaeology, and ethnobotany while earning in 1981 a B.A. in Anthropology and completing extensive coursework in the Department of Biological Sciences. His undergraduate research on archaeological seed remains earned him a President's Award for Research Excellence and laid the foundation for a career in Ecology and Natural History. For 30 years, Feller served as Chief Naturalist for the New York City Department of Parks and Recreation where he led environmental education and conservation initiatives throughout the city. Since retiring in 2014, he has continued to contribute to the field as a consultant on ecological restoration projects. Reflecting on his time at UAlbany, Feller credits Department of Biological faculty members such as Dr. Margaret Stewart and Dr. Werner Baum with furthering his appreciation for field biology and encouraging him to think broadly about the connections between biology and other areas of study. He advises students to pursue what genuinely interests them and to remain open to learning beyond the boundaries of any individual discipline.



Stacey Haas
Class of 2002

Stacey Haas: Expanding Opportunities in Science Education

Stacey Haas earned her B.S. in Biological Sciences and Teacher Education Certificate from UAlbany in 2002. Since graduation, Haas has taught science and has been involved in the development and implementation of upper-level coursework at Guilderland High School. During her tenure at Guilderland High School, she has created three innovative elective courses that include Introduction to Biotechnology, Introduction to Bioethics, and Introduction to Clean Energy Technologies. Reflecting on her time at UAlbany, she credits the rigorous B.S. in Biology program with helping her develop effective study habits and the much-needed skills to succeed in today's secondary education. Haas encourages current and future students to take advantage of opportunities such as study abroad programs and to seek out experiences that broaden their understanding of the world.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY BIOLOGY ALUMNI STORIES



Thomas Joyce III
Class of 2017

Thomas Joyce III: From UAlbany Biology to Serving Women's Health

After earning his B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in December 2017, Thomas Joyce III continued his career by earning his M.D. from St. George's University School of Medicine and an M.B.A. from Western Governors University in 2022. He then completed his residency in Obstetrics & Gynecology and now serves as a staff physician with Northwell Health in Staten Island. During residency. Joyce was recognized with several teaching awards and received the Society of Laparoscopic & Robotic Surgeons (SLS) Surgical Excellence Award. He credits UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences with providing the critical thinking plus communication and collaboration skills that prepared him for medical school and patient care. Joyce is especially grateful for the mentorship of Dr. Caro-Beth Stewart and fondly recalls opening his medical school acceptance letter during his Human Physiology class where his professor celebrated the occasion by surprising him with cookies at the next class. Outside the classroom, Joyce took part in undergraduate research, an active member of several student organizations, and volunteered with UAlbany's Five Quad Volunteer Ambulance Service. Looking back, Joyce encourages future healthcare professionals to pursue their goals with dedication, passion, and endurance. He also hopes to reconnect with UAlbany by mentoring students interested in healthcare.



Amanda Kimler
Class of 2018

Amanda Kimler: Building a Career in Patient Care and Healthcare Leadership

After earning her B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 2018, Amanda Kimler built a career in healthcare and now works as a Registered Nurse Case Manager at St. Peter's Hospital. In her role in the Cardiac Care Unit, she helps coordinate patient care and supports patients and their families as they prepare for discharge from the hospital. Although Kimler initially considered a career in veterinary medicine and environmental conservation, her experiences at UAlbany helped encourage her passion for healthcare. One of the most influential parts of her undergraduate experience was her involvement with Five Quad Volunteer Ambulance Service (Five Quad VAS) where she developed leadership skills, gained valuable experience, and formed lasting friendships. Today, Kimler provides mentorship for new employees, serves on various committees, and helps create resources used throughout her department. Looking back on her time at UAlbany, she credits her biology education with providing the foundation for her commitment to delivering high-quality patient care.



Christian Martinez
Class of 2017

Christian Martinez: Bridging Biology, Data Science, and Education

Christian Martinez earned his B.S. in Biology with a minor in Chemistry from UAlbany in 2017 and has built a career that includes higher education, data analytics, and research. After completing his undergraduate studies, he earned an M.S. in Cognitive Neuroscience from the CUNY Graduate Center where his thesis examined early neural markers of autism spectrum disorder in infants. Today, Martinez teaches at John Jay College of Criminal Justice and Brooklyn College with plans to expand his teaching to the CUNY School of Professional Studies. He also has his own consulting firm where he provides analytics services for small businesses and professional development training for New York City employees. Recently, he received a CUNY Open Educational Research grant that supported the development of his textbook, Reproducible Research Using R, as well as the NYC Open Data Student Gallery. Reflecting on his time at UAlbany, Martinez credits the Department of Biological Sciences for providing a strong scientific foundation and opportunities to explore his interests which continue to influence his approach to teaching, research, and professional development.



Sevinj Mursalova
Class of 2022

Sevinj Mursalova: Pioneering Neuroscience and Biomedical Innovation

Sevinj Mursalova earned her B.S. in Biology with a minor in Neuroscience from UAlbany in 2022 and has continued a research career in neuroscience and biomedical innovation. As an undergraduate, she conducted research at the UAlbany's RNA Institute under the mentorship of Dr. Andrew Berglund where she developed a passion for scientific discovery and gained valuable experience in molecular biology and RNA-mediated diseases. Following graduation, Mursalova spent nearly three years as a research assistant in the laboratory of Dr. Robert Langer at MIT conducting research on drug delivery, biomaterials, and nucleic acid delivery systems. She is currently completing her master's thesis in Neurobiology at Boston University and conducting research at Harvard Medical School and Massachusetts General Hospital where she is developing nanoparticle delivery systems for the brain. Reflecting on her time at UAlbany, Mursalova credits the education, mentorship, and encouragement she received from the Department of Biological Sciences faculty and staff along with her research experience at the RNA Institute with helping shape her scientific career. She also has a special thanks to Jesus Frias and scientists Dr. John Cleary, Dr. Ken Halvorsen, and Dr. Arun Chandrasekaran for their guidance and support

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY BIOLOGY ALUMNI STORIES



Roma Tarar
Class of 2020

Roma Tarar: From UAlbany Biology Student to Future Radiologist

After earning her B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 2020, Roma Tarar continued her journey toward a career in medicine and is now graduating from the New York Institute of Technology College of Osteopathic Medicine. This summer, she will begin training as a physician in Diagnostic Radiology. Tarar credits her time in UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences with helping to shape her path through supportive faculty mentorship, hands-on research opportunities, and a strong sense of community. She is especially grateful to Dr. Meyerhoffer, Dr. Elise Vogt, and Dr. Robert Osuna for encouraging her passion for science and medicine.
Looking back on her undergraduate experience, Tarar says UAlbany taught her the importance of collaboration, learning from different perspectives, and staying curious throughout her career. As she begins the next chapter of her medical career, she looks forward to reconnecting with UAlbany and supporting future students interested in healthcare careers.



Christina Testa
Class of 2025

Christina Testa: Turning a Passion for Science into a Public Health Career

Christina Testa earned her B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 2023 before continuing her education at the University where she completed a Master of Public Health in Epidemiology in 2025. Her fascination with science and a enrolling in an undergraduate course in infectious diseases helped shape her future career in public health and epidemiology. Today, Testa works as a Population Health Assistant at Saratoga Hospital where she helps improve patient outcomes by addressing chronic disease care across the health system. Reflecting on her time at UAlbany, she credits her Biology Degree with helping her discover her interests and career goals. She encourages current students to seek out internships, build meaningful mentorships with faculty and staff, and take advantage of the many resources available to support their academic and professional goals.



Connie Woytowich
Class of 1999

Connie Woytowich: Shaping the Next Generation of Science Learners

Connie Woytowich earned her B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 1999. Today, she serves as a science educator and curriculum leader at her alma mater, Colonie Central High School, where she teaches advanced science courses and helps create and implement healthcare-related coursework for students. Since graduating from UAlbany, Woytowich has continued her education by earning a Master's degree in Curriculum Development and Instructional Technology, two Certificates of Advanced Study, and a Ph.D. in Educational Policy and Leadership. She is also a New York State Master Teacher and instructs dual-enrollment college courses in subjects such as Genetics and Introduction to Pharmaceutical Sciences. Reflecting on her time at UAlbany, Woytowich credits the Department of Biological Sciences strong laboratory experiences, dedicated faculty such as Alice Jacklet and John Mackiewicz, and supportive teaching assistants Christine Gervasi and Isabella Scheiber with helping her develop the critical thinking, problem-solving, and communication skills that have defined her career. She encourages current students to take advantage of research opportunities, build relationships with mentors, and remain open to the many careers paths a degree in Biological Sciences can provide.



Guy Young
Class of 1988

Guy Young: A Leader in Pediatric Hematology and Research

Guy Young earned his B.S. in Biology from UAlbany in 1988 and has gone on to become a leader in pediatric hematology. He currently serves as Director of the Hemostasis and Thrombosis Center and Director of the Clinical Coagulation Laboratory at Children's Hospital Los Angeles while also holding the position of Professor of Pediatrics at the University of Southern California Keck School of Medicine. Throughout his career, Young has authored more than 200 peer-reviewed publications including articles in leading medical journals such as Blood, The New England Journal of Medicine, and The Lancet. Reflecting on his undergraduate years, he credits UAlbany's Biology curriculum with providing a strong foundation for success in medical school and his subsequent career in medicine and research. As a member of the UAlbany soccer team throughout his undergraduate years, Young notes that the leadership, teamwork, and communication skills he developed as a student-athlete continue to influence his approach to overseeing multidisciplinary clinical and research teams today.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

COMMUNITY OUTREACH AND ENGAGEMENTS

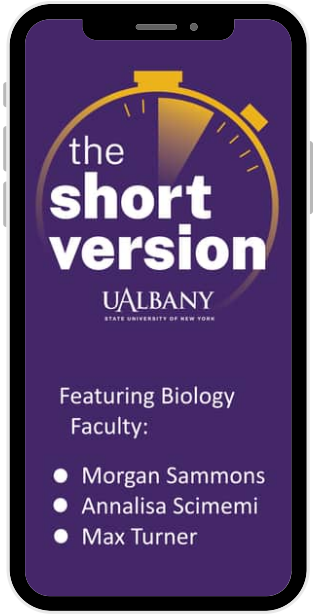
FACULTY PODCASTS



Morgan Sammons

Brain as blueprint: Morgan Sammons on what computers can learn from evolution (November 19th, 2025)

Morgan Sammons, associate dean for natural sciences and mathematics in UAlbany's College of Arts and Sciences, takes us behind the scenes as neuroscientists, mathematicians, physicists and nanoscale engineers at UAlbany are working together to advance to the field of neuromorphic computing and design the next generation of powerful computers inspired by the human brain.





Annalisa Scimemi

Decoding Dementia: Learning the Brain's Electric Language (March 4th, 2026)

Annalisa Scimemi, a neuroscientist at UAlbany, explains how her lab is examining the electrical signals of the brain to gain a better understanding of how Alzheimer's disease affects cognitive functions and behavior. She also shares how her research is clarifying the ways we encode spatial information to navigate the world around us, and how this knowledge could someday be used to train self-orienting robots.



Maxwell Turner

In the Fly of the Beholder: Brains, Vision & AI (January 21st, 2026)

Maxwell Turner, a fly neurobiologist and assistant professor in UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences, explains why we've all been underestimating fruit flies — and how his research to understand how vision works in their brains may one day help humans with visual deficits see the world more clearly.

PODCAST Find these podcasts and more at: https://the-short-version.simplecast.com/

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

COMMUNITY OUTREACH AND ENGAGEMENT

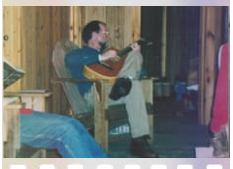
SPOTLIGHT ON DIPPIKILL: REMEMBERING A BELOVED RETREAT AND PRESERVING ITS FUTURE

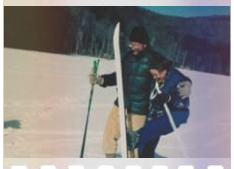












Located just 65 miles north of UAlbany in the southern Adirondacks, Dippikill has been a place where the University at Albany community has come to explore, learn, unwind while enjoying its landscapes and outdoor experiences for 70 years. The name "Dippikill" is believed to come from the Dutch phrase diepe kill which many interpret as "deep stream," while others believe it means "small stream." Located in the Town of Thurman, New York, the more than 1,000-acre Dippikill retreat combines outdoor activities with opportunities for environmental and conservation education.

Owned by the University at Albany Student Association since 1956, its forests, streams, wetlands, ponds, and surrounding mountains serve as a living laboratory where students and faculty can explore ecology, wildlife, conservation, and environmental science firsthand. For generations, Dippikill has provided opportunities for hands-on learning and research while helping students gain a better understanding of nature and what makes the Adirondack region so unique.

Outside the classroom, Dippikill has served as a place to relax and reconnect with nature. Visitors have enjoyed hiking the trails and taking in the views from Dippikill Mountain, canoeing on the 20 acre pond, fishing, observing wildlife, and participating in winter activities including cross-country skiing, snowshoeing, ice skating, and friendly pickup hockey games. At Dippikill, guests could also step away from the distractions of everyday life and appreciate the simple pleasures of cabin living, gathering around campfires, listening to live music, and sharing stories and conversation with family and friends. The retreat also hosted student outings, field courses, alumni gatherings, vacations, reunions, birthday parties, anniversaries, and weddings.

For Dr. **Christine Gervasi**, a current instructor in the Department of Biological Sciences, Dippikill was much more than a nature retreat. As a graduate student, she looked forward to the Department's annual winter weekend at Dippikill when more than 30 students, faculty, and staff set aside lectures, research, and committee meetings to spend time together. They shared bunkrooms, prepared meals, chopped firewood, skied, sang songs around the fireplace, and played games late into the evening. Those weekends revealed a different side of the Department where professors became hockey players and guitar musicians, students showcased hidden talents, and lasting friendships were formed. "It brought us together as a Department," Christine recalls, "and I have many lively memories of those times."

Dippikill also became part of one of the most meaningful moments in Christine's personal life. More than two decades ago, she and her husband, John, celebrated their wedding at the retreat while welcoming more than 80 family members and friends who stayed in cabins and tents throughout the weekend. Guests explored the grounds in search of toads, gathered around evening bonfires, admired the Adirondack night sky through telescopes, and celebrated together in a setting that many still remember fondly. "Our families and friends still talk about what an amazing time they had," she says, a testament to the lasting memories Dippikill has created for generations of the University community.

In 2024, Dippikill faced one of the most significant challenges in its history when public access was suspended because of budget issues and declining use. The announcement of Dippikill's closure was met with strong opposition from alumni and members of the University community who recognized its importance as a place for learning, recreation, and tradition. During this time, the University at Albany Alumni Association, the Student Association, and University Auxiliary Services worked together to develop a long-term strategy for preserving Dippikill. Their plan included establishing Dippikill as a nonprofit organization under University Auxiliary Services with shared oversight among the three partner organizations. The initiative also includes a plan to increase use, add new programs and events, and help ensure that the retreat remains supportable for years to come.

Although Dippikill is not yet open to visitors, the commitment to preserving its natural beauty and traditions demonstrates its importance to the University community. For the Department of Biological Sciences, Dippikill is much more than a place to visit. For generations, Dippikill has brought together students, faculty, staff, alumni, family, and friends to experience the surroundings of the Adirondack Mountains while building lasting friendships and creating lifelong memories. As plans move forward, Dippikill will continue to provide future generations with the many wonderful opportunities it has to offer by creating even more ways to learn, explore, connect with nature, form meaningful relationships, and share unforgettable experiences.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY BIOLOGY MOURNS THE PASSING OF DR. JON JACKLETT, OCTOBER 23, 2025



The Department of Biological Sciences mourns the passing of Dr. Jon W. Jacklet, a distinguished neuroscientist whose research and four decades of service helped establish neurobiology and biological sciences at the University at Albany. At the age of 90, Jon died peacefully at home on October 23, 2025.

Jon joined the faculty at UAlbany in 1969 after completing his Ph.D. at the University of Oregon and postdoctoral work at Caltech. For close to 40 years, he established himself as a leader in cellular and molecular neuroscience using the marine mollusk Aplysia as the model organism for his studies.

Working with students and collaborators, Jon conducted studies on electrical signaling, circadian rhythms, neural plasticity, and memory. His laboratory became recognized for using Aplysia to explain the fundamental principles of how neurons encode, integrate, and transmit information. Over the years, many of his studies utilized techniques such as electrophysiology, immunocytochemistry, and molecular genetics.

One of his major scientific findings was the discovery that nitric oxide (NO) functions as a neurotransmitter. Jon was among the first to show that neurons communicate not only through direct connections, but also by releasing chemical signals that can spread and influence other surrounding cells. This work helped reveal how nitric oxide synthase, the enzyme that produces NO, contributes to neural signaling and behavior.

During his career, Jon authored 69 publications that included work on circadian biology, how nerve cells generate electrical signals, and the ways neurons communicate. Much of his research was published in leading journals such as The Journal of Neuroscience, Science, Journal of Neurophysiology, European Journal of Neuroscience, and American Zoologist/Integrative and Comparative Biology. He authored the chapter “Nitric Oxide as a Neuronal Messenger,” of which helped establish nitric oxide as a signaling molecule in the nervous system. Jon also pursued interests beyond neuroscience including publishing observations of unusual wildlife behavior on bald eagles.

Throughout his career, Jon received numerous National Science Foundation (NSF), National Institute of Health (NIH), and National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) research grants, published influential papers, and served as editor of the volume Neuronal and Cellular Oscillators (1989). Jon was an active participant in the international neuroscience community. He attended conferences around the world and collaborated on research projects in Mexico City, Tahiti, the Woods Hole Oceanographic Institute, and Calgary. Jon’s research program attracted graduate students from around the world of whom launched successful scientific and academic careers.

As a professor and three-term chair of the Department of Biological Sciences, Jon’s research and administrative insight also played a key role in shaping UAlbany’s life sciences. He helped advance the development of UAlbany’s interdepartmental functional genomics research programs which would eventually be housed in the new Life Sciences Research Building (LSRB). Jon recognized early on that the discoveries made by scientists in the LSRB would be crucial for the “next step” after genome sequencing in determining the function of protein-encoding genes.

While best known for his scientific discoveries, Jon pursued life outside the classroom and lab as well. He was an avid Nordic skier, a highly competitive basketball player who made weekly court appearances with UAlbany faculty and staff, a tennis player, and a licensed pilot.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

UALBANY BIOLOGY MOURNS THE PASSING OF DR. COLIN S. IZZARD, MARCH 4, 2026



The Department of Biological Sciences at the University at Albany mourns the passing of Dr. Colin S. Izzard who died on March 4, 2026 at his residence with his family by his side. A scientist, educator, colleague, and friend, Colin contributed to the study of cell motility and to the development of imaging methods that changed how scientists observe living cells at the microscopic level.

Born in Crowborough, Sussex, England, Colin studied Biological Sciences at the University of Cambridge where he earned his Ph.D. In 1967, he joined a core of scientists studying cell motility at the University at Albany. Over the course of his career, Colin rose through the ranks to become a full professor in the Department of Biological Sciences and remained an active member of the University's research and academic community until his retirement in 2004.

Over the years, Colin's research focused on the mechanisms of cell adhesion, contractility, and movement. He studied how cells attach to and move across surfaces by employing various advanced light microscopy techniques including photomicrography, cinematography, and video microscopy. He was credited for his development and the use of Interference Reflection Microscopy (IRM) to study cell adhesion in living cells. By using IRM, Colin was able to reveal how cells form and regulate focal contacts with their environment. His research was supported by a number of external grants which included a National Science Foundation award titled "Molecular Basis of Cell-Substrate Adhesion" (1987–1991). This award supported investigations into the molecular mechanisms underlying focal contacts between cells and their substrates.

During his tenure at UAlbany, Colin authored over 20 publications with much of his research being published in leading journals such as Journal of Cell Science, The Journal of Cell Biology, Experimental Cell Research, Cell Motility and the Cytoskeleton, Journal of Morphology, Cell Biology International Reports, and European Journal of Cell Biology.

In addition to his research at UAlbany, Colin took part in training students and scientists in microscopy and imaging technologies. He served as Director from 1993 to 2012 of the internationally recognized short course Optical Microscopy and Imaging in the Biomedical Sciences which was held annually at the Marine Biological Laboratory in Woods Hole, Massachusetts. Through this program, he helped educate and train generations of researchers in cutting-edge imaging techniques used across the biological sciences.

Colin also served for more than 20 years as Co-Director of the Optical Microscopy and Imaging Facility in UAlbany's Department of Biological Sciences where he helped develop and maintain shared imaging resources that supported a wide range of research across campus and within the Albany scientific community. One example of this work was Colin serving as co–principal investigator on a $433,891 grant from the National Science Foundation to purchase a confocal laser-scanning microscope for UAlbany's Optical Microscopy and Imaging Facility. This instrument allowed researchers to study biological specimens such as neurons and other cells and tissue with far greater clarity and resolution. The resulting Confocal Laser Scanning Facility officially opened in 2000 and further advanced the imaging capabilities at UAlbany while supporting researchers from other colleges, research institutions, and industry throughout the Capital Region. Since then, the Department has continued to build upon Colin's legacy of excellence in imaging by expanding the facility with instrumentation that includes a Zeiss LSM980 Confocal Microscope with analysis software and just recently an Evident VS200 Slide-Scanner and Loader System.

Colin's expertise in scientific imaging was recognized internationally. In 1998, he served as a judge for the prestigious Nikon Small World competition that annually celebrates excellence in photomicrography and the beauty of images captured through the microscope.

Beyond his scientific achievements, Colin had a deep appreciation for music and family. He loved classical music and enjoyed attending performances at the Saratoga Performing Arts Center. The greatest joys of his life were his wife Sally of 56 years, their son Colin, daughter-in-law Elann, and his grandchildren Teah and Ewan Colin Izzard.

We extend our condolences to Colin's family and friends. The University at Albany, the College of Arts and Sciences, and the Department of Biological Sciences recognize and honor his lasting contributions to the scientific community and to the University. Through his research, teaching, and mentorship, Colin inspired generations of students and helped advance a better understanding of cell adhesion and motility in living cells.

UALBANY
Department of Biological Sciences

DEPARTMENT OF BIOLOGICAL SCIENCES UPCOMING EVENTS

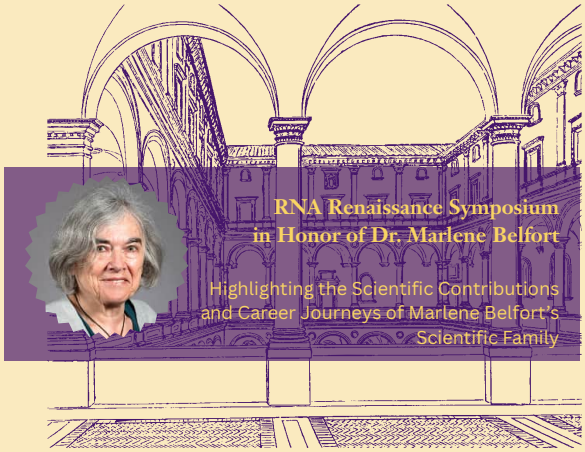
- Fall 2026 Mini WISC

Thursday, September 3rd 2026
(Registration Deadline 8/28)



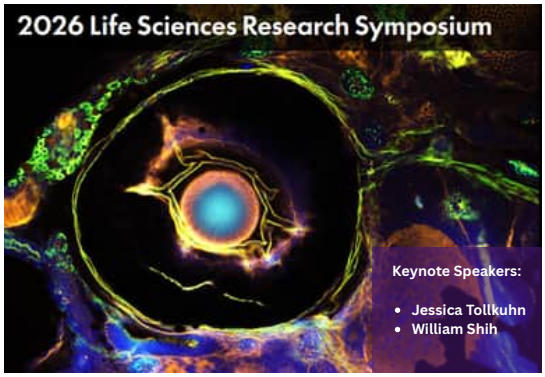
- RNA Renaissance Symposium

Wednesday, September 9th, 2026



- 2026 Life Sciences Research Symposium

Tuesday, October 13th, 2026
8:45A - 4:30P
D'Ambra Auditorium



You can follow us on:

Biology Department Websites:

Main website
www.albany.edu/biology

Information on Undergraduate, Graduate, and Certificate programs
www.albany.edu/biology/programs

Biology Department Social Media

x.com/UAlbanyBiology

bsky.app/profile/ualbanybiology.bsky.social

www.instagram.com/UAlbanyBiology

www.tiktok.com/@.biologyualbany

www.mastodon.Social/@ualbanybiology

www.linkedin.com/company/biology-at-ualbany

To Donate to the UAlbany Biology Department:

Donating to the Department of Biological Sciences at UAlbany is one of the best ways to show your support for an institution that has produced and continues to produce generations of scientists, academics, healthcare professionals, and successful individuals contributing to all areas of life.

You can donate online by:

- Going to the UAlbany Department of Biology website (albany.edu/biology)
- Clicking 'SUPPORT THE BIOLOGY DEPARTMENT'



UALBANY